**tethering death**

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# tethering death

by kj_crwn

Summary

“Glad to see you back among the living,” Phainon says through a yawn, clearly having spent the night in the uncomfortable chair in the infirmary by Mydei’s side. Like he often does.

Mydei’s head hurts. Just the regular kind of pain, easily managed by ignoring it until it goes away. But what makes it worse, is the confusion at his predicament. The memories returning to him in death used to vary in time and people who appeared in them. *Why* is it always Phainon nowadays?

“Fuck you,” Mydei says, hoarsely. He feels like he is losing his mind.

Phainon’s mouth locks mid-yawn and he blinks down at him stupidly, tilting his head with confusion. It’s probably fair, he hasn’t even done anything to earn Mydei’s ire as of late.

or; Human brain lives for a few more minutes after dying, replaying the most cherished memories. Mydei starts seeing Phainon after each of his deaths.

Translation into Russian (Русский) available: here
Translation into Chinese (中文-普通话 國語) available: here

- Translation into 中文-普通话 國語 available: 【授翻/厄敌】tethering death如死缠身 by Anonymous
- Translation into Русский available: Посмертная связь by yaomei

# Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*Valorous death before glorious return.*

One simple phrase, a conviction every Kremnoan shares. Bearing the title of the Crown Prince, it has been seared into Mydei's very core.

A warrior's death is a subject of reverence for Kremnoans, rivaling those who follow the Death Titan with utmost devotion. It's almost logical, seeing as Strife and Death are but two sides of the same coin. Two-thirds of the Titans of Calamity.

For all their worship, Kremnoans rarely contemplate the consequences of one's demise.

Grief has always been looked down upon, as all who have fallen in battle are awaited by the places of honor reserved for them in the afterlife. In the army, Mydei has witnessed many family members smiling through their tears at the memorials hosted for their deceased relatives during the desertion from Castrum Kremnos, careful not to show the sorrow they experienced lest it be viewed as disrespect.

What does it matter what happens after, when you have already achieved the greatest honor you could dream of?

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

But what *does* one see when their body ceases all its functions?

It’s a question he should have known the answer to before anything else. Death and the horizon stretching with freezing water raise him through almost a decade of his life, one agonizing moment at a time. By irony’s fate, there are no memories of the past stored in his brain to recall upon the moment of death, only the vicious cycle repeating itself day in and day out. Lungs forever twisting with the burning sensation, water spilling through his lips each time he gasps back into life.

The blinding light shining through the water’s surface as he yet again drowns in its depths is the first thing out of the ordinary that he has witnessed in however many years. He reaches out to it with his hand, foolishly attempting to clutch at it. Once he resurfaces and coughs mouthfuls of water out, he sees the bright star in the dark sky, unmoving, as if it has been waiting for something.

It takes only a few more days for the Sea of Souls to spit him out of its clutches, suddenly done with its unyielding torture. He props himself up weakly, still half-submerged in the water as he observes the star and, for the first time in his life, gains a sense of purpose.

A wish for something other than, *‘Please, let it end.’*

He crawls through the blackened shores and teaches himself to walk on the legs he had never used on land before. It is shaky and he stumbles on every step, falling onto the ground and cutting himself on sharp stones until he leaves a trail of golden blood in his wake. Fortunately, the movement isn’t too dissimilar from treading through the water. It’s the first skill he learned on his own, instinctually, when his body gained enough muscle and strength to do anything other than flail.

Slowly, he makes his way through the land, following the star until he discovers something that resembles civilization. A concerned woman finds him in the fields, fretting over the frostbitten limbs and malnourishment in words he cannot understand just yet. He watches her curiously as she drapes a red coat over him, carrying his small figure back to the village where people eventually help him out.

It takes a while to learn a language for the first time. Despite the adults helping him as much as they can and teaching him the necessary skills to take care of himself on his own, he never develops a feeling of belonging or affection for the village. In the future, he might be grateful for them, but he won't remember their names or the location of the settlement. Just an outsider, kept in stasis until he is old enough to move on from there.

Then, a warrior passes by the village about a year in.

He hears of it from other kids. She intends to stay a few days, restock the supplies, and set out to her homeland after a battle that had left her as the sole survivor. He doesn't particularly care when they tell him, not until a day later when he is play-fighting with another kid and she sits on the bench nearby, watching them with careful consideration.

He isn't as scrawny as he used to be when he first arrived at the village, bones no longer breaking at the slightest impact due to insufficient diet. Or lack of food in general. He found out it isn't normal for your stomach to feel like it's attempting to devour itself all the time rather quickly. But the boy he is fighting against is older than him, taller by a head, and holding more strength in his muscles.

He is usually able to avoid any direct punches and is quicker on his feet than other kids. This time, his opponent manages to wrestle him into place before kicking him in the stomach and sending him stumbling back.

The other kids cheer at the action, having never once taken the side of the strange foreigner.

He clicks his tongue in annoyance as he lands on the wooden fence, one of the rusted nails catching him on the forearm. He pays it no mind, used to the pain more intense than that, and instead pushes himself off the wooden structure. He uses the momentum to kick right into the boy's knee to throw off his balance. Then, he delivers a firm punch to the jaw, putting his entire body weight into it, making him yell in pain as he stumbles a few paces back.

He startles when the woman grabs his arm out of nowhere, having never noticed her approaching them in the first place. Her grip on his wrist is painfully tight—enough to bruise—as she looks at his wound with narrowed eyes.

“You are bleeding with ichor, child,” she says. A statement rather than a question, but her gaze asks for elaboration.

He doesn’t answer, yanking his arm out of her grip. An action possible only because she allowed for it.

“He doesn’t speak much,” a boy he was fighting with tells her, spitting a few times onto the ground with red liquid before a tooth follows.

He sees some adults starting to make their way over, possibly to check what the fuss is about, as the woman’s narrowed gaze moves to his face, eyes jumping from one point to another. A man walks close enough to ask whether everything is alright, but no sound comes out of his mouth when she continues.

“You bear striking resemblance to our late Queen,” she muses, grabbing him by the chin and twisting it this and that way to take a better look. “Your eyes are a perfect replica of hers, and so are your delicate yet sharp features.”

Ignoring the stifling silence falling around them, he only feels the agitation at being handled like an unruly animal. He clutches at her forearm to keep himself steady and sinks his teeth into the flesh of her hand, a metallic taste filling his mouth.

The woman doesn’t let go as he expected. Instead, she simply laughs. Doesn’t even twitch. “Fierce cub. Befitting of the child of Gorgo,” she comments with a smirk and finally releases her hold on him, palm stained with crimson. He swipes his hand at his mouth, smearing the blood further as he stares at her in defiance. “Tell me, boy, what’s your first memory of?”

He doesn’t trust her. He wants nothing to do with the woman. And yet, he can’t help the feeling of anticipation rising from deep within at the prospect

of learning something, anything, about his origin. “Sea,” he eventually responds with reluctance, much to her satisfaction.

The villagers are all too eager to let him leave with the warrior when they learn of his possible connection to the city-state called Castrum Kremnos. Afraid of what, he didn’t know at the time.

On the first night, once they are far enough, she decides to test her hypothesis. She drives a knife right into his heart and welcomes him back to life with a smile. She couldn’t have taken a stray child back without being certain about his identity, she explains. He is too confused to think much about it, beyond the vague impression of being glad it hurt less than drowning.

It is the first time he sees a vivid memory in a brief moment after death, feeling like he is living through it again. For a few minutes, he felt himself resting on a stranger’s hip as she carried him away, bundled in the warm cloth and with her hand covering the back of his head protectively. The first act of kindness he ever experienced.

It’s at ten years old that he learns his name is Mydeimos, the lost Crown Prince, and that when one’s body ceases all its functions, you relive your memories.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Death becomes a common currency to him, a teenager assembling a detachment army outside of the borders of his homeland. One that he hasn’t ever stepped foot in. Krateros finds him once Mydei’s soldiers start gaining renown for their achievements, separate from Castrum Kremnos, yet hailing from it. His mentor teaches him all he can, from refining Mydei’s fighting skills to the traditions no one ever told him about.

Mydei brushes death off as it refuses to take hold of him, discarding the visions as he pushes through to regain consciousness as fast as possible, to keep as many people safe as he can, to tear the throats of their enemies out before someone other than him can get hurt.

It's only once he fulfills the goal that served as his driving force for over a decade and kills King Eurypon, taking the Kremnoan Detachment to Okhema and pledging alliance to the blonde usurper and accepting the title of the Chrysos Heir, that things slow down enough for him to parse through what he's been through. The first nine years of his life, the first contact with the rest of humanity, the process of learning how to *live*, gaining people he cares about and wishes to protect only to lose them one by one, having enough pleasant experiences for them to flash in front of his eyes.

Time to ponder over the subject of death itself and his relationship with it. He finds out he enjoys the peacefulness of it, the adrenaline at meeting his own demise just to spring back up without a scratch left on his body, the process punctuated only by the brief moment of living through the best of his memories once more.

The ability to hear Peucesta's music that accompanied them everywhere again. To watch Perdikkas scold them but still heal them to the best of his ability again. To be teased endlessly by Hephaestion, sparring with him in the dirt as others watch on with exasperation again.

It becomes preferable to the stagnancy of the agonizingly lengthy wait Aglaea put them on, deeming them not ready to move against the Titans. Easier than remembering all victims of the black tide he failed to save. The brief period of no thoughts and sweet emptiness makes it less difficult to live with himself once he finds out he is the reason for his mother's death and his father's spiral into madness.

It's addicting.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

“You are taking longer nowadays, Lord Mydei,” Castorice says quietly, a touch of concern coloring her voice. From the sound of it, she is sitting a few paces away from his bedside as he comes to.

He won't ask how long it took for him to wake up this time. It's enough that the memory felt like it lasted days, witnessing the carefree hours of traveling through cities with his friends, the Kremnoan Detachment at their backs.

Mydei releases a long sigh, scowling silently. He is too exhausted to request Castorice to drop that honorific, it’s not like she’s going to listen anyway. Too proper, too respectful. Even Phainon couldn’t get through her just yet to gain that familiarity, which means Mydei doesn’t stand a chance either.

She is also right in her assessment.

With every death added to the tally, Mydei struggles to open his eyes again just a little more. He leads a battle with himself, subconsciously clutching onto the tranquility of it, hoping against the hope it might be the last time. Guilt stabs him in the gut every time, but he can’t help it. Is it really so selfish of him to wish for rest? Hasn’t he gone through enough?

He will fight to the best of his ability as long as the curse deems him fit to uphold the prophecy, taking care of his people and standing in their defense. But it won’t stop him from childishly seeking a way to relieve the pain of his immortal existence.

Blindly, he reaches the small table at his bedside with his hand, grabbing the glass of water resting in the exact same spot on it as it always does. It’s a tradition, at this point, the movement is practiced and performed while barely awake.

He pushes himself up in the bed just slightly so he doesn’t choke, downing it in one go. He will feel sick later for not giving his stomach time to adjust.

“Perhaps I’m finally getting closer to earning the luxury of eternal sleep,” he muses drily, finally opening his eyes. Castorice watches him, hands folded neatly in her lap. “We could test that theory if you came closer.”

Castorice’s lips twist with sorrow, knuckles turning pale as her grip tightens. “Please do not joke like that,” she says mildly. “You are an important figure, Lord Mydei. We cherish your company, and I am unsure whether some of us would have been able to recover from such loss.”

Mydei snorts without any humor. It’s not that he doesn’t think he is useful. He knows his skills are vital, possibly the only chance at slaying Nikador. But it’s not like he is exceptionally close with any of them. Aglaea would have found it inconvenient. Castorice would have lost someone who understands her domain almost as intimately as she does. Phainon would have mourned the demise of a sparring partner before finding another poor sod to bother.

Maybe if he died permanently, the prophecy would have chosen another worthy soul.

“Do not fret,” he says in an attempt at reassurance. “The curse won’t release me from its hold so easily.”

Castorice doesn’t seem to be appeased by his words, brows furrowed as she studies him. She looks like she wants to say something but changes her mind, sighing softly in resignation. She stays by his side for one more hour, the death she carries with her silent and comforting to Mydei. Familiar.

Until Phainon barges in, voice soft but gaze heavy as he takes a seat on Mydei’s bed. It doesn’t even take five minutes before they’re throwing scathing remarks at one another that neither of them means, Castorice chuckling quietly into her hand.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Mydei isn’t a stranger to taking his own life.

The whole ordeal loses some of the significance when you willingly drown yourself in the sea as a child, hoping it might cut your misery short. Or if you are forced to bash your head into the stone—*pierce your skull, slice your throat, put your own guts back in your body, tear the*—to kickstart the healing factor in order to save your allies one too many times.

It usually happens out of convenience. But not always.

Plagued by the guilt and weight of the lack of control that has been plucked from his hands by fate itself, he finds a quiet spot in the ruins just outside of Okhema and sits down, his favorite dagger clutched in his hand.

It’s been a long week. Month. However long, time loses meaning at a certain point.

But it doesn’t change the fact that he feels like something is consuming him alive. It’s been too long since the last time somebody killed him, allowed the visions containing not a single negative thread of emotion to swim into the forefront of his brain, overriding everything else.

He knows it’s unbecoming of him to fall apart so easily. Would anyone still want to follow him if they knew their leader isn’t as strong as they think? Mydei would have lost the respect and loyalty of Kremnoans that he worked tirelessly to gain. The rest of Chrysos Heirs would have regarded him with pity, realizing he doesn’t deserve a seat among them.

Now, though, he is completely alone.

No one to see him crack into pieces or to interrupt him.

Mydei desires nothing more than to *rest*, to be done with the fucking prophecy. He has given so much of himself already, what else does he have to lose? There is nothing of himself left to offer.

He wishes to slay Nikador but would forego the responsibility to carry the Coreflame of Strife in a heartbeat. He doesn’t want it. Mydei witnessed its

corruption firsthand. He refuses to doom the last of Kremnoans like his father had done.

It would be so easy to position the dagger against the wall and push his body against it, to pierce through that one vulnerable spot on his spine and be done with everything for good. But that's not what he is seeking right now, nor would he ever consciously permanently take his life, he doesn't think.

Mydei rests his back against a piece of column that failed the trial of time, gazing at the eternal figure of Kephale, bleeding to uphold the burden of life on their shoulders.

He tightens the grip on the dagger and slits his throat in one decisive movement, making sure to sever both of the arteries. He clenches his free hand into a fist to stop the instinct to cover the wound and stall the bleeding, pushing through the dizziness as he waits for the blood loss to take him.

He chokes on ichor as he comes back to life again, smiling at nothing in particular at the image of one of the first Kremnoan feasts hosted in Okhema. He relishes in the joviality of warriors bathing in the glory of a won battle and Krateros toasting to their Prince, gazing down at him like he imagines a proud parent would have. Years before those eyes turned impatient and demanding, refusing to understand Mydei's motives.

Mydei keeps his eyes closed and takes his life again.

He sees Anaxa, smirking at Mydei from across the room after their short collaboration to get back at Cipher for one of her countless pranks, Aglaea off to his side and pretending she hasn't the slightest clue what they were up to for once.

Hephaestion's warm breath against Mydei's skin, laughing silently as Mydei drank his diluted honey brew, Ptolemy looking up at them with a glare from his beloved book.

Dancing on the battlefield at Phainon’s side, covering each other’s blind spots with ease as they tumbled into a draw of yet another competition.

Golden liquid stains his skin and attire so thoroughly there is barely any other color visible when he opens his eyes by the time he reaches the tenth death. The giant statue of Kephale keeps bleeding alongside him. He stops counting after that.

Mydei is leaning against the wall of one of the houses at the market's entrance, sluggishly trying to recall the schedule he planned out for today a few days prior. The pulsing ache at the center of his forehead proves it difficult to form more complex thoughts. He should have stayed in or holed himself up for another day or two.

“This is new,” Phainon’s voice rings from his side, sending another spike of pain through Mydei as he flinches at the sudden loud sound.

He squints at Phainon, but the man is too preoccupied with staring at Mydei’s neck, one hand already halfway up before Mydei can react. Not that he thinks he would be capable of much at the moment.

His breath doesn’t stutter and his heart doesn’t skip a beat, but Mydei keeps himself as still as he can once Phainon’s fingertips make contact with his throat. They trail along the line, left to right, leaving goosebumps in their wake.

Mydei should have considered the option of breaking into Phainon’s room and stealing one of his chokers to cover the scar up when he woke up in the morning to find it still there. Unfortunately, he was too busy dealing with his head attempting to split itself in half.

“I didn’t hear about you going on a mission,” Phainon continues with a frown, eyes snapping back to meet Mydei’s, thumb still on the carotid artery. “Were you in a fight today?”

Mydei's body doesn't retain any scars. There wouldn't be any healthy tissue left otherwise.

Perhaps it's his healing factor retaliating against his valiant efforts of forcing himself into the gates of the afterlife. It would be a little foolish to be stuck with that line on his neck for the rest of eternity, though.

Mydei shakes his head minutely, wincing at the way the movement just makes the pain worse. He closes his eyes and tries to breathe through it, clenching his jaw. He would kill himself again if it meant getting over this faster, but since this could be a result of overusing the curse, it might just backfire on him.

His pain tolerance is incredibly high. This headache of his would probably leave an ordinary person dead if it hurts him that much.

"What's wrong?" Phainon asks with urgency, possibly unused to seeing Mydei out of sorts.

"Migraine," he whispers, closing his eyes in hopes that taking away one of the senses will calm it down. It's a lost cause, but he can hope.

"Why are you out here, then?" Phainon questions incredulously, voice pitched lower to accommodate Mydei's sudden sensitivity.

He grabs Mydei by the forearm and gently steers him away from the market and back in the direction of Marmoreal Palace, presumably with the Chrysos Heirs' personal quarters in his mind. Mydei sighs and lets himself be led, keeping his eyes shut. He trusts Phainon to keep him safe from tripping or bumping into any citizens loitering around.

Phainon spends the entire day trailing after Mydei hopelessly, even after the migraine subsides enough to be at a manageable level. Mydei is too exhausted to fight him on it, instead choosing to humor him this one time.

It's— it's nice. Pleasant. Having Phainon's attention directed solely at him. Mydei already knew that. He thrives on pushing the other man's buttons on occasion until Phainon's vision seems to narrow to him and no one else. But

it’s different when Phainon is softer than usual, taking care to relieve Mydei’s pain in any way he can.

Phainon stays by his side all the way until morning comes, inviting himself over to Mydei’s quarters for late dinner and distracting him until he is too sleepy to kick him out properly. When Mydei wakes up a few hours later to the sight of Phainon drooling onto one of Mydei’s pillows, he purposely keeps his mind as blank as possible and gets up to the bathroom.

A flushed image of his face greets him in the mirror, much to his mortification. He splashes some cold water onto the warm skin and inspects himself more thoroughly. The scar on his neck is almost completely gone. He hopes Phainon didn’t inspect it too closely and that he missed the way multiple lines were overlapping over his skin so much it appeared as just one.

Chapter End Notes

> originally planned to upload this in one go, but then i decided against it because posting in parts will stop me from rushing through writing
>
> being pedantic is going to be my downfall. aside from writing and then fact-checking just to find out small details are off so i hunt for them to adjust, i also had these 3k words ready ages ago, but i rewrote the whole thing spontaneously :)). originally, i was going with the mydei-lived-for-9-years thing i did in one of the other fics but then i randomly changed my mind because i'm too much of a nerd to go so far from canon again. instead you're getting a made up continuation of mydei's backstory ig
>
> i apologize there isn't that much of phaidei in this part, it will pick up almost immediately in 2nd chapter. i will make up for it with them being disgustingly in love and still pining lmao
>
> Edit: lmfao i forgot the very first line???? I really should stop uploading at 2 am

hope you enjoyed!
@kj_crwn on twt
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that

# Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> It happens again. And again, and again. And every time he dies, all he sees is Phainon, Mydei's brain strangely fixated on him to no end. He notices the tendency for quicker regeneration compared to before as well.
>
> It's a little overwhelming and quite disconcerting, to put it mildly.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"The human brain is wired in the most intricate of ways," Anaxa tells him in the Hero's Bath one day, gesturing with his half-empty goblet.

The only reason he didn't leave Okhema as soon as his business was done was that Aglaea happened to be otherwise preoccupied for the entire day. It might also have something to do with Hyacine trying her best to convince him he would benefit from even just a few hours of relaxation. He always had a soft spot for her.

Castorice and Hyacine sit not too far away, conversing quietly with one another. Mydei doesn't entirely understand why he was chosen to be the audience of one when Hyacine is right there until Anaxa continues.

"It's the last part to die after one's passing."

The pieces click together, and Mydei realizes Anaxa is looking for a first-hand recount from him. He could have just asked. Alcohol, even in small quantities, makes him more prone to going off on the tangents.

"Research has been conducted on the significantly injured warriors as well as individuals suffering from sickness who had succumbed to death, and yet healers were successful in the resuscitation." Mydei resists the urge to

yawn, idly wishing Phainon was there to get on Anaxa's nerves and speed things up. But it's fine, he will get to the point soon enough. "Vast majority of them expressed being subjected to the sudden visions of their life, witnessing the best of their memories. Supposedly, it is approximated to last a mere few minutes after the person's death."

His single eye lands on Mydei, holding his gaze dispassionately, finally done beating around the bush. Mydei raises an eyebrow, waiting for the question.

"So, how does it transpire for you?" Anaxa finally asks. "I imagine you have the most unique understanding of the act of dying itself out of all of us, even Castorice."

Because Castorice assists with what he cannot do—guiding souls to cross the River of Souls into the afterlife. Her curse places her on par with Death itself, and yet she would still be unable to satisfy Anaxa's curiosity.

"I always see just one memory," Mydei explains easily. "The length of it varies. Sometimes, I get a minute before I'm back. Sometimes, it's hours until I can open my eyes again, usually stuck reliving whatever it is." Days, if his body faces too heavy of trauma and it happens to align with his psyche taking a toll. "I don't recall them ever repeating."

Anaxa nods, brows furrowed in concentration as if he is mentally writing notes on it. "We must take your curse into consideration, of course. The number of memories might be limited due to it, and the time allocated for it could depend on the amount of damage done to your body and its ability to heal it.

"I wonder what would have happened if you were placed in a prolonged coma—would you be stuck in a single memory for days on end even if it's no longer one of the pleasant ones, or would it transform into a different one eventually?" Anaxa mutters under his breath, more to himself than anything else. Mydei doesn't point out he already knows the answer to being gone for more than one day. His gaze snaps back to focus after a few seconds, regarding Mydei once more. "What of their nature?"

Mydei shrugs, tipping his head up to stare at the high ceiling of the baths. Okheman architecture never disappoints in its details and dimension. The question is simple, he can answer without giving away how they affect him.

“Every moment of my life that has left an impression can make an appearance. I’ve never relieved a memory of training on my own, reading a book, or being idle. Although, I was thrown back to the conversations with people that seem mundane at first glance.”

It could be due to his longevity, leading to running out of sufficient memories considered as above average when most things become shrouded in disinterest with time. Not to mention that he encountered death innumerable times—his brain could be struggling to dig through all the memories to find a new one to display to him. He doesn’t say any of that. It’s Anaxa’s job to draw conclusions.

“Haven’t seen any of my other deaths either despite them having an impact, but there were a few instances where I found myself back at the sea again.”

Anaxa nods in understanding, taking a sip from his drink. There is a moment of silence where Anaxa appears as if he is weighing his words. To say it’s uncharacteristic for him would be an understatement. A feeling of trepidation slinks around at the back of Mydei’s mind.

“Would you say that this phenomenon impacts your psyche, consequently impairing your ability to return, so to say?”

There it is.

It was foolish of Mydei to assume anything would have escaped Anaxa’s attention when it entails a subject he is interested in, whether it focuses on Mydei’s personal life or not. He must have conversed with Castorice on the matter already—she was the one who possibly redirected him to Mydei, expressing her concerns while she was at it.

With a small sigh, Mydei levels him with a flat stare. Anaxa doesn’t cower under it nor does he take the words back.

Mydei's lack of response is as good as confirmation and they both know it.

"I had to ask," Anaxa says, quieter than usual. It's the closest thing to an apology Mydei will ever get.

Mydei doesn't particularly give a shit, truth be told. He walked into that one, and he knows Anaxa won't meddle unless it starts impacting the efficiency of his duties.

"I will give you an opportunity to ask one last question," Mydei decides to change the subject, losing the will to continue with this interrogation. He participated long enough.

"That's indeed immensely benevolent of you," Anaxa replies sarcastically but it loses the bite when he takes him up on the offer, nonetheless. He is incredibly easy, at least when it comes to these things. "Does love influence the experience at all?"

Now, Mydei didn't expect to hear *that*. It almost pulls a burst of laughter out of him. People always assume he is incapable of such emotion. "Has it escaped your attention that I have never entertained any lovers?" He asks with a wry smile. He fell into bed with a few soldiers from the Kremnoan Detachment in his youth, but that's not exactly common knowledge in Okhema.

Anaxa seems amused by the reaction. "That's not the question I asked," he points out, insufferably, then taps his free hand against the junction of his neck and left shoulder. "You are not an oblivious man, Mydeimos."

Mydei rolls his eyes, both at the usage of his full name and the not-so-subtle allusion to Phainon. No, Mydei isn't oblivious to his own feelings for the man, but he isn't exactly eager to act on them either. Or acknowledge them much, really.

He rises from his seat and stretches briefly, bones popping from sitting in one position for too long. "I'm afraid that doesn't concern you in the slightest, *Anaxa.*"

Mydei takes pleasure in the way Anaxa's features twist in a sneer at the nickname he loathes so much. Not that anyone cares about it. To get some more harmless payback, he slips the goblet out of Anaxa's fingers and downs it in one go, setting it on the table and smirking as Anaxa glares at him with viciousness he could never back up.

Mydei raises an eyebrow in challenge. He wouldn't mind going against their Scholar, but Phainon would whine about someone stealing his sparring partner once he heard of it.

Anaxa lets out an aggravated breath but otherwise tampers down on the irritation, his gaze once more serious when he regards Mydei. "Would you mind terribly reporting to me if there are any new developments?"

"I cannot begin to guess how many times I have risen from the dead," Mydei points out slowly. He is as familiar with it as he is with being alive. "The whole process never strayed from its usual course."

Anaxa waves his fingers at him in clear dismissal, then runs them through his hair, sweeping the fringe back from his eye. "Humor me."

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

He tears through an enemy's throat with his gauntlet, turning just in time to see the sharp edge of the blade heading straight at him with inhuman speed. The last thing he sees is the glint of steel in the sun. The last thing he feels is the beginning of a cut on his throat before everything goes blessedly numb as his spine is severed. The last thing that passes through his mind is the realization that he hasn't ever had his head cut off before.

Does the curse have limitations other than the one spot on his spine? Could it truly be the last time——

Sparks fly as Mydei blocks the sword, skidding back as he digs his heels into the ground. He grins at the thrill that surges through his veins at the sheer power backed behind the blow directed at him. There is nothing quite as riveting as a partner that doesn't hold back against you, the knowledge of the trust in your ability to match the skill and fight back. The metals make a grinding noise as they unlock their weapons.

Mydei loses track of time as they fight until he sidesteps Phainon and slashes his back with the claws of his gauntlet, sending him stumbling. It could be considered a cheap trick, but they say all is fair in war and love. Their spars could be dragged up to it. Probably. In Mydei's case, at least. It's not like Phainon hasn't done the same before either.

"I *just* got that coat," Phainon whines, their spar momentarily forgotten. He tries to crane his head to peek at the damage done to it, spinning in a circle like an idiot when he still cannot catch sight of it.

It pulls a snort out of Mydei against his will. He shouldn't find something so stupid that funny, but Phainon makes it hard to be truly annoyed at him. Mydei notices the sly grin on his face when he steps closer just a fraction of a second too late. Phainon already throws himself at him with his sword raised between the two of them before he can defend himself adequately.

Mydei has just enough time to angle his arm around Phainon's body, otherwise staying completely still and letting him push the weapon against his jugular, expression extremely self-satisfied for pulling one over Mydei.

"I won," Phainon beams, putting the slightest pressure on the blade against Mydei's skin. It's not nearly enough to draw blood.

Mydei hums, pressing himself more firmly against it. "Did you?" He smirks back, tracing a sharp metal claw over the ridges of Phainon's spine through the torn layers of fabric.

Phainon's back arches at the cold touch, grip on the sword slackening as his body pushes itself against Mydei's chest with the motion. His eyes widen just a bit in shock, not having expected to have the situation spun around on

him. He should have known better by now, after countless instances of fighting with and against Mydei.

“Ah, I hate you,” Phainon mumbles as his head makes a dull thud when he lets it fall on Mydei’s shoulder with resignation. “It’s a draw.”

Mydei lets out a quiet but full-hearted laugh, jostling Phainon as his shoulders shake. His hand settles more firmly on Phainon’s waist to hold him close despite knowing it’s a bad idea to indulge himself like this.

The last thing he notices is the tip of Phainon’s ear, slightly redder than his usual complexion, could it——

Mydei opens his eyes with a sharp intake of breath, head resting on the muddy ground at an awkward angle. It hurts like a bitch, more than any of the resurrections have ever hurt before. Excluding the ones where his body required to be recovered and brought back for observation from the severity of his injuries.

He grits his teeth and picks himself up soundlessly, eyes locked onto the enemies’ backs turned to him. The mindless beasts must have deemed him dead and no longer a thread. Mydei is about to rectify that mistake.

Throughout it, he barely notices the way the corners of his lips are still quirked up, musing at the back of his head that he ought to ask Phainon whether he ever fixed that stupid coat.

Mydei doesn’t reflect much on it. His thoughts briefly jump to the conversation with Anaxa a few months back before disregarding the connection to it.

It’s not even the first time he sees Phainon in his death, after all.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

The most common cause of Mydei’s deaths is blood loss.

It’s also the least painful one, that drags him under quickly and thoughtlessly. He is so used to it that he can no longer recognize the signs in time, always taken by it at the very last moment. It makes sense, given the way he hasn’t a single care for any wounds sustained in the heat of the battle. Mydei is known to take risks of getting cut and stabbed just to get closer to the enemy to have a clearer shot.

He throws a spear at one of the targets, watching the figure’s body be pinned to the wall behind it. There aren’t any hostiles in close range anymore, so he decides to take a brief moment to catch his breath, heart working overtime to pump his blood at an accelerated speed. And, suddenly, Mydei feels a staggering wave of dizziness hit him.

He curses lowly and tries to keep himself steady as his knees buckle underneath him, already aware of what’s to come.

Black sparks fly through his vision, slowly multiplying. He only catches a glimpse of Phainon turning to check on him from where he is fighting against his own opponent, pushing it off himself roughly as he looks at Mydei in alarm, before everything fades to——

The book falls onto the ground unceremoniously, landing on its open pages with the hardcover up. The title engraved onto it mocks them silently. Mydei looks down blankly, arms crossed. It’s a big volume; the weight of it must have further influenced the impact. There isn't any possibility the paper isn’t creased, if not torn. Heads will roll once Anaxa finds out.

Phainon crouches next to the victim of his carelessness, one hand covering his mouth as he stares at it mournfully. He cautiously reaches out to the book before wincing and retracting his hand, too terrified to check the damage.

“The gravity of the situation might be too much to handle,” Phainon agonizes with the terrible play on words.

Mydei rubs the bridge of his nose in exasperation. He won't admit he finds it a little humorous, even more so given the fact it's Phainon who is the culprit. He sure hopes Anaxa won't consider him an accomplice by association, though.

It's a very valid concern, actually. And now that he thinks about it, he certainly should make himself scarce as soon as possible before any witnesses stumble upon them. "Right. Best of luck to you." He turns on his heel to do just that, but unfortunately, he doesn't get very far.

"Where do you think you're going?" Phainon asks, clutching onto Mydei's robe like a child. Mydei whirls around to glare at him, yanking on the material to set it free from its assailant. Phainon only grips it harder and Mydei is forced to let go before it tears. "We are in this *together."*

And while, usually, that's a very correct statement seeing as they somehow end up attached at the hip regardless of what they are doing as of late, Mydei refuses to bear the consequences of *this.*

"What the fuck do I have to do with this?" Mydei asks, suddenly alarmed. He would fight by Phainon's side even if the battle was rigged against them in the worst of ways, but dealing with a furious and bitchy Anaxa is not something he will endure willingly.

"You tripped me up," Phainon accuses, letting go of Mydei to cross his arms with a huff.

"I did no such thing." Mydei may have tugged on his cape a little. "You stumbled over empty air."

"Would that *empty air* be honorable enough to help me, then?" Phainon asks sarcastically, staring at Mydei pointedly.

Mydei wonders when he has become so transparent that he can't even push Phainon around without being detected. Or perhaps it's the inability to lie to him convincingly.

Ugh. *Fine.*

Clicking his tongue in irritation, Mydei crouches alongside him and gathers up the book which Phainon doesn't feel brave enough to inspect. That's the perfect Chrysos Heir right there. Titans help them all. Mydei is careful not to add to the damage of it or he truly will become an accomplice. A cursory glance tells him at least five pages are crumpled, and one is nearly torn in half. He looks back to Phainon.

Phainon reads his blank expression accurately, promptly collapsing onto the ground with a loud groan.

"I'm glad to have known you." Mydei stands back up in one swift move and makes to flee the crime scene, but Phainon's hand is faster, wrapping around his ankle with too much strength. He tries to shake it off, cursing himself for choosing to wear sandals instead of armor today as it makes it easier for Phainon to keep his iron grip around it.

"You're not about to abandon your comrade in need, are you?" Phainon asks, aiming for threatening but ending up pathetically resigned. Like Mydei just refused to help him cover up murder instead of intending to leave him alone with a defiled—by Anaxa's standards—book of all things.

Mydei looks mournfully at the exit one last time before deciding to——

He regains consciousness slowly, as reality comes back to him piece by piece.

His body is carefully arranged on the ground, far from the graceless sprawl he finds himself in whenever he dies on his own. Mydei opens his eyes slowly, blinking a few times to regain his bearings. He looks around, noting the dead bodies littering the ground all around, a half-collapsed wall of a building right behind him.

And Phainon—of course *Phainon* is there, it's starting to feel like the man is haunting Mydei—sitting beside him with his knees raised, and one hand propped up on them, his head tilted back to rest against the wall, eyes closed as he controllably breathes in and out. His whole right arm is soaked in blood, and the only reason Mydei doesn't feel the spike of panic is because it's the wrong color.

He pushes himself up quietly, swiping his hand through his hair and wincing at the matted feeling of it at the back of his head. He probably hit his head on the way to the ground while dying. He must look like a disaster.

It’s a small mercy that Phainon doesn’t look much better. His hair is stained pink with blood, cuts marring his cheeks and shoulders, having ditched his coat at some point, and a bruise is already forming on his jaw.

He is obviously exhausted and dirty, likely wishing for nothing more than to get back to Okhema so they can clean up and rest. And yet he dragged Mydei all the way to safety and protected his dead body until he woke up. With Mydei’s track record, it could have taken anywhere from a few minutes to actual days. Taking the memory he witnessed into consideration, it couldn’t have been more than an hour. Phainon got lucky.

“You are so stupid,” Mydei still says, thinking back to the damn book that they ended up bribing a Kremnoan specialist to restore it to its original condition before Anaxa could notice.

Phainon jolts, head banging against the wall in shock. “Hello to you too,” he says with a wince, lifting his hand to rub at the spot. “You’ve got an odd way of saying thanks.”

It’s not that Mydei doesn’t appreciate it. He just— Why would anyone bother when he is so used to this?

“You should have dragged me to the camp and let healers handle me,” he says, nudging Phainon’s leg with his foot. “Or better yet, leaving me behind would have been the most optimal course of action.”

Mydei is more than capable of catching up. He would have done another sweep of the area after waking up, ensuring they covered everything. He is quite certain anyone else would have also chosen that route, knowing he would be fine sooner or later.

Phainon gives him a look that says he thinks Mydei is the stupid one out of the two of them which is rich coming from him. “You know me better than

that. I’m supposed to watch your back and yet—” He cuts himself off, shaking his head slightly. “It’s the least I could do.”

Mydei resists the urge to roll his eyes, standing up to stretch his muscles. Figures that Phainon would be beating himself up over this. Perfectionist to the core. It doesn’t matter that Mydei hasn’t had to worry about support not even once in all the fights they have gone into together. He cannot say that about anyone else when he cannot bring himself to depend on them to cover for him in a way he trusts Phainon.

“I died because I allowed myself to be stabbed one too many times, Phainon,” he says, bending his neck to the side until it gives a slightly concerning crack. “My back was always secure.”

“I should have noticed,” Phainon argues with a weak glare, brushing his fingers through the blood and dust coating his forehead.

“You should accept you cannot prevent every wrong thing from happening, Deliverer. You are doing more than good enough,” Mydei retorts patiently. He reaches down with his hand to Phainon, waiting until he grasps his fingers around and pulls him up to his feet. “I could not ask for a better partner than you.”

Phainon smiles at him, a small and genuine thing compared to his standard wide grin. He looks pleasantly surprised by Mydei’s admission, squeezing his hand once before letting go.

“Should we check the perimeter for stragglers?”

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Mydei lurches forward into a sitting position, blood filling his mouth from having bitten on his tongue to instinctively hold back the yell as he had woken up from the nightmare. He runs one hand down his face, inhaling

deeply to calm down his racing heartbeat. It doesn't work quite as well, his breath turning into panting as the image of Leonnius' body flashes through his mind again, bones protruding from his thighs as he stares through Mydei with vacant eyes.

In the nightmare, he doesn't express the relief of being able to deliver the news of Mydei's achievements to the afterlife. Instead, his bloody corpse blames Mydei for the misery brought into the Kremnoans' lives, cursing him for leading their squad into a trap. Dead eyes bore into him with contempt as Mydei watches the enemy slice through his legs, frozen in place by an invisible force.

The dream makes sense, logically. Mydei always suspected the words were meant just to keep him calm in the retreat. And he never forgave himself for being unable to recover his dear friend's body. The guilt and grief eat at him during the nights, modifying the memories just to torture him some more for his failure to protect his loved ones. He's seen that scene play out in five different versions in altering settings, always unable to save his companions despite being *right there.*

Mydei shakes his head to get rid of any thoughts and gets up. He can't stay in bed, letting his brain circle through the familiar thought process that will only make him spiral further. His muscles lock in protest as he takes the first step, but he pushes through and stumbles into his private bathroom.

He rests his hands on the sink to support his weight and looks up into the mirror, his breathing pattern still too quick. A sickly pale face greets him, the red of his markings standing out like mortal blood, hair disheveled from the restless sleep, and dark shadows underlining his golden eyes.

So much for the fierce image of the Kremnoan Crown Prince.

His eyes fall to the scissors resting off to the side, usually used to cut through the bandages healers still insist on wrapping around his wounds. On an impulse, he picks them up and takes the few unsteady steps to the shower. He all but collapses in the very corner, pressing his back against the tiled walls as firmly as he can.

He feels like a coward, running from the ghosts of his past. But at the moment, the irrepressible need to witness the moments of his first friends' happiness and their well-being is stronger than anything else. He has to erase the vision of dead bodies and broken promises, to see the happier memories of what used to be.

Mydei positions the scissors directly above his racing heart and sinks them into his flesh in one firm move, breath escaping him in one short burst as the bone is pierced through and his heart is torn open. He yanks the scissors out to speed up the process, ichor streaming down his body and onto the tile.

It doesn't take long until his heartbeat stops entirely, and his eyes slip shut on their own accord.

Only to see Phainon instead, some inconsequential memory of walking through the market while they argue over the value of Phainon's latest purchase. It can't have lasted more than half an hour before he wakes up again. Frustration burns through him, overshadowing the confusion at the realization that he hasn't seen anything other than Phainon for quite a while now.

He repeats the ordeal, scissors sliding through the ribcage with more ease as the bone is still fragile from the recent recovery, and grits his teeth through the sharp pain.

Phainon, breathless with a laughing fit that overtook him so strongly he cannot even explain what it's about as Mydei watches on for an unbelievably long time, fighting against the pull on his lips.

Phainon, speaking in quiet tones as he confesses to some of his insecurities, deep into the Curtain-Fall Hour when all of Amphoreus slumbers aside from the two of them, sat side by side with Kephale's figure as their only witness.

Phainon—

Mydei exhales shakily when he opens his eyes next. It’s frustrating, but it would be bordering on insanity to attempt the exact same thing for the fifth time and expect a different result. Casting away the initial reason for this spiral for the moment, he thinks about the way he was only able to see *Phainon* out of all possibilities. For a while now, actually.

The thought is concerning.

He reaches up and blindly turns the shower on. He barely feels the freezing water cascading over his head as he watches the gold dilute and swirl down the drain.

At least he doesn’t see Leonnius’ corpse every time he closes his eyes anymore. Now, it’s the last memory of concerned bright blue eyes pushing into his personal space like an annoying pest, his care so obvious even through the sharp jabs at Mydei.

What would Phainon think if he knew Mydei broke apart so easily from one trivial dream?

Would he—

As he cuts the thought off, resolve steels itself somewhere within Mydei’s ribcage where his abused heart thuds in a sluggish beat. He doesn’t want to find out.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

It happens again. And again, and again. And every time he dies, all he sees is Phainon, Mydei’s brain strangely fixated on him to no end. He notices the tendency for quicker regeneration compared to before as well.

It’s a little overwhelming and quite disconcerting, to put it mildly.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Mydei comes to quietly, with a breath stuttering into his lungs as if it's trying to resume the motion that wasn't performed for a long time. His mind is shrouded in a fog, throat impossibly dry and limbs stiff.

There is a vague memory still clinging to the forefront of his brain, of bright hair and eyes, days filled with easy companionship. He frowns, trying to catch it before it can slip away from him. Was he dreaming about it? It seems unlikely. His nights are barely ever spent reliving the pleasant memories.

No, he only sees those under one circumstance.

Does it mean he died again?

*Why doesn't he remember it, then?*

He tries to move but his body feels too heavy, managing only a small spasm in his legs. There weren't many instances where he had been incapacitated to this extent, he must have encountered something particularly powerful if he was left in such a state. Could it be black tide?

With great effort he manages to blink his eyes open, squinting against the blurry vision. The first thing he recognizes is that he is at the healer's, the décor of the room as familiar to him as his own quarters. The light is dimmed, curtains drawn to shield him from the intense sunlight that would have shined directly onto his bed otherwise. He appreciates the effort.

When he manages to shift his head just slightly, he notices the even *more* familiar figure of a man slumped onto his bed, head propped up on the forearms and light hair strewn on the mattress as soft snores echo in the quiet room.

Mydei winces, eyes slipping shut when pain attempts to split his head open again. Some memories come back to him. A few scenes of walking side by

side, pushing each other, and bickering over the smallest of things out of boredom resurface in quick succession. Walking into an unknown city together and observing as Phainon tries his best to haggle over an antique of sorts. Those evidently don’t portray what happened before Mydei must have died as his brain sluggishly supplies that it’s from an expedition that took place two years ago. Aglaea forced them into taking it when they were acting out a little too much in Okhema from restlessness, making use of their overflowing energy to help a settlement falling to the black tide.

The few moments that just flashed through his mind he can recall stretching over the days. Is it his brain supplying more than he might have initially seen after death, or did it really take that long to come back?

Question after question buzzes in his brain even though his body feels heavier than when he first woke up. With some struggle, he opens his eyes again and immediately zeroes in on Phainon. He is dressed in loose-fitting clothes for once, but his back is bent at a strange angle like he didn’t intend to fall asleep at all when fatigue took over. There are almost-healed cuts littering the slivers of skin that Mydei can glimpse, hair unwashed and fingers fisted into the bedsheet with desperation.

Mydei wants to wake him up because that position cannot be comfortable and Phainon *will* be whining about the backache for days to come. His voice fails him, lips barely moving when he tries to command them to speak. There is no hope to shift his hand over and grab Phainon’s, or even to tug on his hair. Two of his fingers twitch but that’s the best he can do, frozen in his own body.

He blinks a few times when his eyes threaten to close without permission, his head swimming in the onslaught of dizziness. It’s already a lost battle before he can even think about it, overtaken with sleep as suddenly as he had woken up.

Chapter End Notes

> the chapter would've been up yesterday but my cat got sick so there's that lmao
> i also shifted some scenes around and added new ones, so it will take a

bit longer to get the next part out but the overall word count will be higher than what i initially estimated

i know it's not easy to stab through the ribcage and into the heart (especially with scissors) but like. mydei is crazy strong, it's very much so within the realm of possibility for him

for once i don't know what else to say, so that's a miracle on its own?

so i will mention this instead. i recently found this song — suffocate by nathan wagner and holy fucking shit, i keep replaying it because it's so mydei (and phaidei, but mostly mydei) coded after 3.1 aaaaaa

hope you enjoyed!
@kj_crwn on twt
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that

# Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> There is pity in the way Anaxa regards him. “Most people would be making use of what little time we have, then.”
>
> “It would be cruel, considering that we know not how or when we will meet our demise, a permanent one in my case. Why give life to something that can only end in agony?”

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Why are they so mean to me?” Phainon asks resignedly, jerking his arm up and down. The chimera dangles in the air along with it, its teeth embedded in Phainon’s sleeve with vicious tenacity.

It’s been hours since they were first roped into supervising six young chimeras. Mydei wasn’t listening when they were told why the animals couldn’t be roaming free just yet. He and Phainon were left to their devices in the corner of the Garden of Life, citizens occasionally coming by to fawn over the adorable creatures. They might be ogling Phainon just a bit while they’re at it, but one impatient glare from Mydei manages to do a good job of sending them away.

“They sense you’re not so saintly as you like everyone to believe,” Mydei says over the loud purring of four chimeras curled up on top of each other in his lap.

Mydei has a sneaking suspicion that Aglaea orchestrated this to force them into getting rest. He might be inclined to admit that they’ve been overdoing it with their expeditions out of Okhema to help the settlements filled with too many people to be allowed past the gates to the Eternal Holy City.

“That’s just rude. I *am* a good person,” Phainon protests half-heartedly, but his shoulders shrink down on himself in dejection just a bit. It appears to be one of the days where he doesn't take the snarky comments well. Mydei doubts anyone else would even notice.

“You are the best of us,” Mydei replies without missing a beat, with as much conviction as he can put into it so that Phainon doesn’t get any ideas about it being untrue. “But you are also a menace when you want to be.”

Phainon chuckles at that, tension easing. He pulls his arm closer to himself, trying to pry the chimera’s jaw open with a finger to get it to release him without being too forceful. It growls at him, the sound muffled in the fabric. Phainon sighs and looks at Mydei helplessly.

Alright, it might be time to rescue him.

Mydei leans over, careful to not jostle the animals resting in his lap, and gently picks up the unruly chimera by the middle with one hand, reaching around with his other to rub against its snout and allow it to scent him. It lets go without much fuss, tilting its head to lick his fingers.

“Of course they love you,” Phainon mutters under his breath, but there is nothing but fondness sparkling in his eyes.

“It’s because you are too restless,” Mydei explains with a hum. Phainon is generally a ball of energy and anxiety in equal measure, and the chimeras react to it in a stand-offish manner.

On an impulse, he grabs Phainon’s hand and presses their palms together, then brings them close to the chimera very slowly. It lets out a small *awoo* before nudging against their hands, nuzzling its head against Phainon’s. Phainon’s fingers twitch like he wants to scratch its fur, but Mydei tightens his hold, Phainon’s hand relaxing immediately. He then moves their hands together, petting along the chimera’s fur gently until it warms up to the touch before retracting his hand entirely and letting Phainon do his thing.

The chimera doesn’t notice the change, purring as Phainon continues on. Phainon’s jaw is slacked open, as his eyes shift rapidly from the animal to

Mydei, like he’s asking whether Mydei is also seeing what is happening.

Mydei chuckles at it, watching as Phainon smiles at him as if he had hung all the stars, eyes sparkling with——

Mydei jolts awake, muscles spasming as he regains the feeling and control over them all at once. He feels lost for all of a second before his surroundings make sense and his brain realizes he’s been through another death. Right.

“Glad to see you back among the living,” Phainon says through a yawn, clearly having spent the night in the uncomfortable chair in the infirmary by Mydei’s side. Like he often does.

Mydei’s head hurts. Just the regular kind of pain, easily managed by ignoring it until it goes away. But what makes it worse, is the confusion at his predicament. The memories returning to him in death used to vary in time and people who appeared in them. *Why* is it always Phainon nowadays?

“Fuck you,” Mydei says, hoarsely. He feels like he is losing his mind.

Phainon’s mouth locks mid-yawn and he blinks down at him stupidly, tilting his head with confusion. It’s probably fair, he hasn’t even done anything to earn Mydei’s ire as of late.

“What have I done this time?” Phainon asks tiredly, except it’s filled with affection as he passes Mydei a glass of water without missing a beat.

Mydei huffs and takes a few careful sips of the drink, watching as some of the strain disappears from Phainon’s shoulders as he leans back onto the chair, hair falling into his eyes.

“Exist,” Mydei says flatly. He is confident half of his problems wouldn’t have ever occurred if not for Phainon, be it bringing him headache after headache, annoying him into eventually doing whatever Phainon wants, or being a menace in general.

But, Okhema wouldn’t feel as much of a… home as it does, if Phainon didn’t make it so.

The way they naturally gravitate toward one another, always aware of where to find the other without asking. Seeing through the cracks of the carefully crafted masks, understanding the insecurities and worries without the need to express them aloud.

“Sorry, I guess.” Phainon snorts quietly, swiping his hair back from his face. He smiles sleepily at Mydei but makes no move to head to his own bed now that he has witnessed him regain his full health. “You will have to endure my presence until Titans themselves force me away.”

Mydei closes his eyes briefly, inhaling deeply and holding it in his lungs.

He knows that devotion runs deep through Phainon’s veins, mirrored by Mydei’s own conviction. They are so intertwined—have been for a while now, really—that perhaps it is a natural trajectory for his brain to be wrapped around Phainon’s very existence so tightly.

It doesn’t mean it isn’t annoying and frustrating to the bone, and that there isn’t fear lurking around. That one day he will forget the faces of his closest friends without the option to relive the more carefree days he spent with them. But it might be too late to prevent this change.

Mydei releases his breath, leaning back against the headrest as he looks outside the window at the statue of Kephale.

“I suppose it’s a good thing we are the Titan slayers, then.”

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Mydei gives Phainon a blank look when the man drops down onto the stairs next to him, hidden in the alleys of the Marmoreal Market. He specifically

found a spot that no one ever bothers wandering into, a lone crook between houses. He was absolutely positive not even Phainon would be able to track him down there. If things continue in this manner, Mydei will start thinking he is destined to be pestered by him at every waking moment of his life. Annoyingly, he cannot say he would mind it as much as he should.

Phainon, undeterred by Mydei's lack of enthusiasm, smiles at him briefly. Not one of his usual grins, but instead something fragile and thin.

"You are the strongest person I know," is his opening line which only serves to increase Mydei's confusion. His eyes shift off to the side with uncertainty for a second before snapping back to Mydei. Unusual, to say the least. "In *every* definition of the word, actually."

"And the Okheman sun shines eternally," Mydei responds dryly and gestures to the sky. "Any other astute observations?"

"You are ruthless on the battlefield and the number of foes slain by your hand is so high I'm uncertain we could even attempt guessing it," Phainon continues as if Mydei didn't say a word. It's more on par with his regular behavior. "You may die quite a bit, but you have yet to forfeit a single victory since the risks you take allow the rest of us to advance or you manage to deliver a killing blow in turn." Phainon bites his lips like he doesn't know whether he should proceed. "Does it have to be that way, though? I won't pretend to understand how harrowing of an experience dying must be, but…"

Foolish sentiment. Mydei is—

"You are used to it, I know," Phainon says bitterly, running fingers through his hair in resignation. Mydei stares at him, mouth clicking shut when his retort is taken out of his mouth. "And that's just worse, don't you think? You shouldn't be *used to it.* You may not die permanently, but your life isn't expendable. I am aware there are things only you can do and risks only you can take thanks to it but even so—"

Phainon cuts himself off and drags his hand over his face, letting out a long exhale. His eyes are dejected when they meet Mydei's again.

“You don’t realize how excruciating it is to watch your lifeless body drop to the ground or wait for hours upon hours for you to wake up. Hours, sometimes days. Spent on sitting there hopelessly.”

“No one asked you to do that,” Mydei bites back defensively.

Who knows, maybe it would do him wonders if Phainon disappeared from his bedside. There is a possibility his brain would have caught up and stopped the onslaught of memories related solely to Phainon. He ignores the twinge of panic that rises at the idea.

*“I know,”* Phainon returns with a glare that deflates as quickly as it appears. “But what else am I supposed to do? It must be horribly lonely, to face death on your own just to wake up with no one by your side. I… You have to know you are *not* alone. It doesn’t have to be you and whatever is going on in your head against everything else.”

Phainon doesn’t say it outright, but the way he looks and Mydei makes him think he is staring right *into* him.

It’s a scary prospect.

To have someone who can see through you so plainly. Where even without knowing what exactly it is that plagues Mydei, he still instinctively tries to cover for the vulnerable spot in Mydei’s psyche that he himself refuses to acknowledge on most days.

“It’s a curse I must bear on my own,” Mydei reminds him, shoving the thought to the back of his mind. “And even if I could, I wouldn’t place this burden on anyone else’s shoulders other than mine.”

“And you call me a self-sacrificial idiot,” Phainon retorts with a sigh. He seems determined when he speaks next. “I don’t know if it will help any, but I will continue to do my best to be at your side whenever you return to us. So that you know there is always something, someone you should come back for,” Phainon continues, smiling lightly like he isn’t essentially giving Mydei a will to cling to life. “You wouldn’t want me sitting there uselessly

all the time, would you? Imagine how angry Aglaea would be if I missed too many of my duties."

Deliriously, he feels like both Phainon and the part of Mydei's brain that he himself doesn't have access to—the one responsible for showing him the best moments of his life according to it—are unbelievably synchronized. Both set on turning his worldview upside down.

"We can't have that," he responds after a moment to Phainon's last sentence.

Well.

It's not like he can do anything about it either way, is it? He might as well let himself get guided by it.

Perhaps it's time to let go of the moments of the past that used to put him back together as easily as they tore him to shreds.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Teeth gritted, Mydei slides between Phainon and the enemy at the very last moment, taking the hit meant for him. One that would have killed Phainon on the spot. Mydei has the ability to spit in Thanatos' face and return without many complications. Phainon doesn't. Mydei isn't about to let him slip away to somewhere Mydei cannot follow.

Phainon whirls around to face him, sword raised just to stumble back in shock when he realizes what happened, rushing forward again to catch Mydei's body. That is exactly what Mydei did not want, he didn't just intercept the lance for Phainon to get stupidly killed because he was fussing about Mydei's death.

"Focus, Phainon," Mydei chokes out and feels ichor spill down his chin.

He raises his hands and clamps them around the lance sticking out of his chest with as much force as he can muster when the enemy attempts to remove it. He is glad for years of training and tight muscle control. Because, despite sensing himself fading fast, he knows the grip won't slip quickly enough for the enemy to recover and strike again.

Phainon's eyes sharpen at the words, eyes blazing with a blue glow as he lets go of Mydei and falls back into a fighting stance, aiming for the——

A choked noise echoes around the table. Everyone's attention turns to Phainon who clamps a hand over his lips. Presumably to stop himself from spitting the food out. Castorice and Trianne share a look, the latter snickering as she shovels another spoonful into her mouth.

"Something the matter, Deliverer?" Mydei asks, stirring his own bowl.

Phainon's eyes snap to him, quickly jumping to the women sitting in front of them, then their food which looks identical to his and yet seems to have no issues, and back to Mydei. He never ceases to amuse.

"Is this— Is this meant to be so bitter?" He eventually asks, glancing down at his meal like he is doubting himself.

"What do you mean, Snowy? It's delicious as always," Trianne pipes up unhelpfully.

"Are you criticizing my cooking?" Mydei questions with a raised eyebrow, finally trying his own food. He is satisfied with how this one came out. He didn't have as much hope for it as it was an experimental recipe he got from an outlander civilian.

"Of course not," Phainon says quickly, taking another bite and releasing a long exhale through his nose at the horrible taste.

Mydei doesn't exactly recall what the initial reason for his anger towards Phainon was that led to this. Even more so, he should probably feel a little guilty about it, now. Phainon had stayed behind while others began eating

to help Mydei tidy up the kitchen, not even once complaining about his hunger or food getting cold.

“Perhaps your tastebuds decided to follow suit in your brain cells' lead and subsequently deteriorated when you weren’t paying attention.” Mydei cannot resist digging at him just a little more, hiding a smirk around a spoon when Phainon gasps, offended. His eyes slip down to where Mydei is licking the spoon clean for a fraction of a second before they jump up to Mydei’s and narrow at him.

“Maybe you’re losing your edge and didn’t notice that your proportions were off or something,” Phainon trails off weakly, clearly at a loss on how to argue on the subject he isn’t knowledgeable about.

“No one apart from you is complaining, Deliverer.”

“Oh?” Phainon reacts, shifting to look to the right and then tilting his head at Mydei. “Aglaea’s expression says differently.”

What? Did he miss one of the ingredients that isn’t to her liking? He was under the impression that he had memorized all of the Chrysos Heirs’ palates.

Mydei glances at her, only to find her face indicating that she is mildly entertained by their antics but betraying nothing else. When he turns back around, it’s just in time to catch Phainon hastily retracting a spoon from Mydei’s own bowl and quickly shoving it in his mouth.

His face lights up in realization before he points at Mydei accusingly, spoon still hanging from his mouth. “I knew you were messing mine up on purpose!”

“You fucking— who allowed you to touch *my* food?” Mydei snaps, lurching forward and taking hold of the damn spoon to try and yank it out just to be petty.

Phainon yelps but clamps his teeth around the metal, refusing to let Mydei have his way. Mydei narrows his eyes and wraps his free hand around

Phainon’s arm to tip him off balance, hoping the surprise will work to his advantage. Unfortunately, Phainon is better than that and so his palm crashes into Mydei’s jaw, pushing his head away as far as he can manage.

And, of course, it only escalates from there.

Their childish squabble lasts longer than it should, food long forgotten and cold. They barely notice Aglaea excusing herself from the table with a shake of her head, or Trianne running off with a laugh. Cas watches silently until Mydei succeeds in his endeavor, freeing the spoon and almost taking Phainon’s tooth with it.

Triumphant, Mydei resumes his meal as Phainon stares at his own with dejection, looking so pitiful that Mydei decides to put him out of his misery. He takes Phainon's bowl without a word and goes back to the kitchen to quickly prepare some honeycakes for him. His own food has already been entirely drained of any warmth, what does it matter if it waits just a bit more?

“Alright, this,” Phainon speaks with his mouth full, gesturing with his fork in a circle around the pancakes, “*This* I can get behind. Exceptional skill, phenomenal execution.”

“Are you quite done yet?” Mydei rolls his eyes at the over-the-top compliments, stirring the contents of his bowl before eating some. The quality is still perfect, if not as satisfying as it was before they got sidetracked.

Phainon hums in fake consideration before spouting off some more nonsense. “Mouthwatering aroma, revolutionary taste. Kisses to the chef.”

“It’s compliments to the chef,” Mydei corrects absentmindedly.

“Are you sure? I heard some ladies in the market saying that and, truthfully, I entirely share the sentiment. Who wouldn’t want to kiss—"

Mydei’s attention snaps to Phainon just in time to see him realize the exact meaning of words that are thoughtlessly spilling out of his mouth, eyes widening and fingers twitching.

“I mean, no. Well, yes, but it’s. The food, really—” He trails off awkwardly, too flustered to think it through. Mydei raises an eyebrow, curious how Phainon intends to wrap the thought up. Or, more accurately, how deep of a hole he will dig for himself. “It’s natural to want to show your gratitude through affection to— it’s about the person who came up with the recipe, of course, not—"

Phainon trails off, quickly sets the fork down, and leans his elbows on the table, resting his head in his hands in embarrassment. His ears are so red that Mydei is surprised there isn’t any steam rising from them.

“I think I will just shut up now,” he says faintly.

He looks so endearing and at the same time pathetic to the core that Mydei bursts out laughing so suddenly that a muscle in his stomach spasms painfully. Phainon just whines into his hands, sliding further onto the table and narrowly avoiding crushing the honeyca——

“…arrange for someone to help you transport him back to Okhema,” Castorice says from what sounds like a few steps ahead. The reinforcements have arrived in time, then. “I could also wait with you until he shows the signs of waking up, Lord Phainon.”

“No, no. There is no need to,” Phainon immediately dismisses the offer from directly next to Mydei. “I will give him one more hour and then I will make do somehow. I got some practice carrying him around, you know.”

It sounds. A little questionable. Mydei would physically wince at the wording if he didn’t regain some of his senses just a few seconds prior, the body still not entirely ready to react in the way he desires it to.

The silence stretches between them before Phainon backtracks.

“His body, I mean. Because he brings victory all the time, but he also gets injured a lot. And sometimes he dies, and someone has to— He barely wants *me* helping him, let alone—”

“It’s lovely that you are there for him when he needs it, Lord Phainon,” Castorice cuts him off tactfully before the rambling can get away from him. Mydei can easily imagine Phainon frantically nodding, relieved at not having to continue speaking.

Mydei manages to slowly dig his fingers into the ground, regaining some of the control. The gesture goes unnoticed by the two.

“Are you sure you don’t want our help moving to a more comfortable setting? You are injured as well, Lord Mydei wouldn’t approve of you pushing yourself too hard at his expense,” Castorice presses on.

Mydei will give her that. Calling on him in an appropriate manner while negotiating with Phainon tends to garner a firmer response. It’s convenient when trying to find out whether Phainon’s opinion can be swayed.

“If it’s one of the times he—”

“Well, if it *is*, he won’t even know I limped my way to Okhema, will he?” Phainon cuts her off but not unkindly. Bone-deep exhaustion seeps through the words, directed at something other than their friend. He releases a small sigh, and his voice is softer when he continues, “Although, it might not matter. Lately, it doesn’t even take—"

Mydei *finally* regains the feeling in his muscles entirely and manages to push himself up with a grunt. Phainon’s mouth clicks shut mid-sentence as he whirls around to face him, tense expression immediately melting into relief.

“You are both wasting time,” Mydei points out.

There is no hope for getting Phainon to abandon his dead body and Mydei suspects almost everyone is aware of the fact by now. But he also should have accepted the help when it was offered, knowing damn well Mydei

would get on his case for not being careful with his own injuries. Awake for it or not, he *would* know.

Not waiting for their answers, he rises to his feet, slightly unsteady. Phainon is at his side within a second, ready to support his weight if Mydei's legs decide to give out after all.

Once upon a time, Mydei would have bristled at Phainon for deeming him incapable of taking care of himself in such a vulnerable state right after a resurrection. Now, he nods at him to communicate that he is fine and lets Phainon walk a little too close to him as they follow Castorice on the way back.

The battleground is filled with carnage as they walk through it, enemies sliced in half or with their limbs detached in clean slashes of a blade. It doesn't fit with Castorice's preferred fighting style.

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"It's all your fault," he says to the back of Anaxa's head, taking satisfaction in the minute flinch it evokes from him.

Anaxa doesn't seem perturbed by his sudden presence at the Grove of Epiphany, nor does he scold him for the deliberately silent approach.

"Lots of things appear to be," Anaxa hums, not taking his eye off whatever book he is studying right now, too engrossed in it to leave the bookcase and read it in the sitting area. "What's the issue?"

Mydei steps to his side and does *not* lean against the rows of books, knowing better by now.

"We had that conversation about how the brain reacts to death," he gets right to the point, aware they both have better places to be. "A few deaths

after it, I started seeing *only* Phainon following each one. It hasn't stopped since. Every memory that appears includes him in one way or the other without fail."

Just like that, the book snaps shut and is carefully slipped back into its place on the shelf. Anaxa looks up at him with something gleaming in his eye that makes Mydei narrow his own. "It's been almost two years since we had that conversation."

*That* throws Mydei off. Has Anaxa been keeping track? He didn't think there was that much significance to their short discussion. Even less so given the fact that Mydei is no ordinary human being, and so he doesn't pertain much to his research beyond being a curious outlier.

"Fascinating," Anaxa hums, crossing his arms. "I did wonder whether it would impact you at all. Since you never followed up, I had concluded that nothing changed. I should have factored in your stubbornness and unwillingness to adhere to the change itself. I did illustrate that brains are the most intriguing of organs, operating in ways we cannot fully comprehend as psychology is a subject that will never cease in its development. My initial assumption appears to stand correct—after having the obvious connection pointed out, your brain seems to have altered the course of action based on intense feelings. It could be a result of a survival tactic."

Mydei ought to feel offended at being treated like an experiment. However, that would explain why Anaxa remembers how much time passed. At this point, the most he can muster up is mild annoyance at him.

"To conclude, you are saying it's *definitely* your fault," Mydei summarizes the short lecture.

"You will thank me," Anaxa waves him off, unconcerned. "What are your thoughts on the matter?"

"It's not entirely unpleasant after getting used to it. The shock of realizing I will not be able to see certain people this clearly again was not something I enjoyed," Mydei decides to tell him, aware it's not the report Anaxa expects

from him. After years spent in his classroom, Mydei knows the professor expects a more thorough account of the proceedings. He always docked points if they missed any details on the long-term assignments.

Anaxa's lips are thin like he wants to dig further but chooses not to push his luck today. "And Phainon?" He asks instead.

"What of him?"

Anaxa gives him a stare that sends Mydei right back to the classroom where he wracked his brain to give a sufficient answer and appease Anaxa enough not to get what usually follows that particular look, which is a quick look to the ceiling as if he is asking Cerces to lend him patience. If he believed in them at all. Phainon was the regular recipient of it.

"Whatever may have changed," he continues before he can even form a more thorough thought on the matter, "and whether his existence has anything to do with it, he is not privy to my experiences with death beyond my physical recovery."

He knows it's the wrong answer the moment it leaves his lips.

And there goes Anaxa's eye briefly rolling up before pinning Mydei with an unimpressed look.

“You two are the most incompetent students I have ever had the displeasure of teaching,” Anaxa says, voice toneless. Mydei wants to argue. He excelled at history and possibly could have become a scholar on the subject in another life. And Phainon was good at debates, he supposes. He wisely keeps his mouth shut. “When anyone dares to question me why I don’t tutor anymore, I will be pointing to you and Phainon.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” The question slips out with a tinge of irritation. He didn’t come here for *this.* It doesn’t matter, as Anaxa moves right past it.

“Common sense suggests that if your bond evolved to be so strong that it transcends the definite act of dying itself as it, presumably, not only alters

your previously unchangeable stream of memories but also accelerates the rate at which your resurrection occurs, you should have either made the fact known by now or that he should have realized *something* shifted."

Mydei blinks at him. He is mildly impressed, Anaxa managed to say it all in one breath. He half wonders if his lung capacity might be larger than Phainon's and how that revelation would probably make Phainon lose his shit a little.

"Don't you two *talk?"* Anaxa continues, pressing fingers to his temple and moving them in a circle. Mydei is unsure whether it's a simple gesture to convey his displeasure with the situation or whether his annoyance has risen so high that it's giving him a migraine. "I was under the impression that you both express your frustrations, let's call them, to one another rather freely. And loudly."

"I made my peace with it by now." The response comes out a touch more defensive than Mydei would have liked it to sound.

Who, in his place, would have revealed to the very source of his dilemma that he is appearing front and center behind his eyes each time he closes them in the moment of death? Not only does it require vulnerability Mydei isn't well versed in showing, but it's also *humiliating*. He might as well outright admit to Phainon he is in love with him to the very core, the kind of love and devotion there is no coming back from regardless of how the circumstances could ever change, and *that* would be less embarrassing.

"Then why are you here?" Anaxa is starting to appear exhausted with the conversation. Mydei thinks he should wrap it up before he is banned from the Grove of Epiphany as a whole for his transgressions of being, by Anaxa's estimation, a moron. He will be more eloquent and vicious with his words when he does it, though.

"You said to report any changes," Mydei replies, fully aware of the smugness that comes with it.

"Ah. You mean this suffering I am experiencing right now is of my own making?" Some slightest traces of humor finally surface in the professor's

expression, almost conveying *‘well done.’*

It’s part of it, sure.

Why wouldn’t he, when the whole ordeal has caused him so much grief? It’s only natural he would come with the intention to get on Anaxa’s nerves, just a little bit, after remembering the promise. Serves him right as the instigator of this mess.

He arrived at the same conclusion as Anaxa already, he isn’t stupid, so he didn’t exactly need his input. It was the denial holding him back from acknowledging it, initially. Fear of change and forgetting the past. Brick by brick, Phainon took apart every wall Mydei had set up, consciously or not, and then placed himself firmly at Mydei’s side before rebuilding the walls into something that could fit them both. He gradually wore Mydei down until the idea of letting go wasn’t so scary anymore.

Mydei still has issues. He still gives his life away thoughtlessly if he sees an advantage to it, expecting to wake up alone and later drown in the regrets of his past running him ragged. Except Phainon is always there, ready to offer silent comfort and easy distraction until Mydei is entirely himself again, even if nowadays he wakes up lighter than ever before.

Phainon still has insecurities that constrict him until self-depreciation threatens to eat him alive. Except Mydei always notices and finds ways to pull him out of the silent spiral as his easy smiles become stilted and small favors turn to him carving himself open for others’ benefit. Words of reassurance, masked in teasing compliments and sharp remarks that get him back on track.

Perhaps, Mydei came to Anaxa because he was ready to admit it out loud. Or, well, Anaxa knows how to read between the lines better than anyone else. There is no doubt he has mapped out Mydei’s thought process to the dot by now. The point is, someone *understands*, now.

Anaxa doesn't seem to share his concerns, entirely unimpressed as he raises an eyebrow at him. Mydei supposes it might be strange. Seeing him, who

has never feared anything in his life and threw himself into impossible battles, shying away from something kinder and softer.

“Why are you still biding your time, Mydeimos?” Anaxa’s question, once again serious, brings him out of his thoughts.

Mydei doesn’t need him to elaborate on the vague nature of the question. “We are the Chrysos Heirs, each of us cursed with the exception of one.” A sole perfect heir who Mydei fell for, the one who will deliver the new era of Amphoreus. He feels pride, knowing the one he loves is the person who is strong and worthy enough to pave the way for the rest of humanity. “Without a shred of doubt, our duty will come at the cost of our lives.”

There is pity in the way Anaxa regards him. “Most people would be making use of what little time we have, then.” It’s a courtesy on its own that he doesn’t ridicule the prophecy at the mention of it.

Mydei shakes his head with a small smile. He does want it—the opportunity to see Phainon in this new light of unhidden love. What wouldn’t he give, for a life without their burdens that are bound to taint whatever moments of happiness he could savor. Maybe he will give in if it’s Phainon who initiates it. Titans know one of his very few weaknesses is that very man.

But for now—

“It would be cruel, considering that we know not how or when we will meet our demise, a permanent one in my case. Why give life to something that can only end in agony?”

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Mydei’s first death after the conversation with Anaxa is a result of his own stupidity, really. Not only that, but he is also subsequently shown the vision of him and Phainon both flunking one of Tribbie’s math tests.

When he wakes up, he feels like the universe is mocking him and Anaxa might be laughing at his misery somewhere in the Grove.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

One by one, arrows pierce Mydei's body as he runs. His thigh, arm, two to stomach, one more to shoulder. He staggers when another hits his shin and severs some of the tendons. It places him directly in the path of another arrow, and he notices it one second too late to block it as it heads right into his left eye, piercing straight through and lodging into his brain, the——

He blinks sleep away from his eyes, stilling when he finally registers what he is seeing. Sun shines impossibly bright, creating a breathtaking effect of a halo and making the already light hair appear almost snow white. Bright blue eyes glow down onto him, grin in place as one hand is stretched out in his direction. Is he still dreaming?

Mydei accepts it sluggishly, too sleepy and comfortable to have complete control over the situation. He is hauled up to his feet with just a tad too much force, making him stumble. Warm hands immediately settle on the skin of his waist to steady him, those beautiful eyes close enough to clearly see the darker outline around the pupil.

Phainon exhales, thumb swiping along one of the red marks. "Are you always like this after waking up?" He asks with curiosity, laughing softly.

The answer is no. He is usually quick to shed the last bits of sleep and get on with his day.

But he always wakes up alone and cold, more often than not roused by a nightmare. Not by a chuckle and a quiet call of his name in a familiar voice, coaxing him into opening his eyes.

“You really shouldn’t be this sweet,” Phainon says when he takes too long to answer. “Are you trying to kill me?”

It’s said so softly, and Mydei is too distracted by the proximity, touch, and remnants of sleep to remember the words later when he will be embarrassed by being caught in such a state, but Phainon——

It’s over in just a few seconds, not enough time for Mydei’s corpse to even hit the ground.

He catches his feet, tearing the arrow out of his head and stabbing the next assailant who’s charging at him in the neck in one swift move. He feels the blood pour out of his empty eye socket; skull already knitted back together as his eye begins the slow process of regeneration. He yanks out the rest of the arrows in quick succession, utilizing them to fight the enemies before he can grab a more suitable weapon discarded by the dead.

His body is back to its unblemished state when he regroups with the rest of his team, Anaxa’s lips twisting in disgust at the amount of gore covering him.

“I wasn’t there for it,” Phainon pouts into the towel that lies on his face much later when they are relaxing in the Court of Seasons. Only two other people are bathing alongside them at the far corner due to the late hour. They are doing a very good job of minding their own business so far.

Phainon *nearly* goaded Mydei into a competition of testing their bodies’ limits in drastic temperatures, but Mydei turned it around into a contest to find out who could hold their breath for longer again. It was easy enough to get into Phainon’s head, stating that, surely, he must have improved since the last time? The answer was very obvious since their first attempt, seeing as Mydei has had nine years of practice in prolonging the time in between the deaths while drifting at the sea. Phainon, too riled up by being challenged on both occasions, did not make the connection and nearly passed out trying to prove himself. Some things never change.

“It lasted a few seconds at best,” Mydei points out for the tenth time, exasperated. "Don't delude yourself into thinking you would have caught that arrow."

Phainon shifts, the towel sliding lower down his face with the movement to reveal the glare he has directed at Mydei. "I would have noticed."

He moves, catching the towel as it threatens to fall and slipping it around his neck before lifting his hand to poke with his index finger below Mydei's left eyelid.

"Or prevented it. I'm resourceful."

"Hmph." Mydei rolls his eyes but doesn't get out of the range of touch.

He told Anaxa he wouldn't act on his feelings. He doesn't intend to.

But the way Phainon's gaze sets on him with a single-minded focus, as if nothing beyond the two of them exists, is not helping in his resolve.

They are both half naked, sweat gleaming on Phainon's chest, hair damp from the steam rising in the hot bath. His choker is gone, for once, the pale skin of his neck tempting Mydei to leave a mark of his own next to the one of the sun. How easy would it be to close the short distance and climb onto Phainon's lap to claim his mouth with only the thin wet cloth between them? To forget about the two individuals not so far away, watching them from the corners of their eyes every now and then. The news of the new development in their relationship would no doubt have been made known to all of Okhema before the end of the Entry Hour.

The poking of his cheek ceases, turning into tracing along the eyelid and then on top of it when Mydei closes his eyes.

Time to get his thoughts back on track.

"Not even you are that fast, Deliverer," Mydei says slowly. Just to get a scoff that clearly states Phainon would like nothing more than to disagree as a response.

Only Phainon would have such unrealistic expectations of himself.

It's part of why he loves him so dearly.

In a moment of weakness, he allows himself to lean his cheek into the soft caress.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Mydei keeps a bruising grip around his own throat with his left hand, enough to cut off the air supply to his lungs as he tries to keep enough of his blood inside his body to allow him to slay just a few more enemies.

It’s a lucky hit placed by the Titankin with a spear that had too much reach when Mydei was busy fending off six others while dodging arrows from yet another one further back. He killed all of them within a few seconds of getting his bearings, but it was enough for the one singular Titankin to get close enough to sever the carotid artery. It’s fatal, he knows that much. He cut through it himself too many times not to realize.

Five more enemies resurface around him, enhanced by the black tide because of course they are, and Mydei feels himself slowing. He feels ichor dripping down from the corners of his lips where it pooled inside his mouth. Can’t swallow it from the injury, can’t spit it out at the risk of worsening the damage and having more blood spill.

If he dies now, it could be anywhere up to ten minutes before he gets up. Will others keep up for that long? Have they evacuated all of the civilians by now? Are there many hostiles left?

He trips one of them up and throws himself onto it, pressing all his weight into the torso and grabbing the head with his free hand. The metallic claws make a grating sound when they dig into it, and then Mydei pulls with all

the strength he’s got left. A sickening crunch, then the sound of tearing and splatter of Titankin blood.

His lungs convulse, demanding oxygen. He might not have a choice in how long he will hold out for anymore.

He watches another one charge at him and the only thing he can do is raise his bloodied gauntlet up and hope it will hold against the impact, no longer able to get back up onto his feet. It’s fine if it doesn’t. He will be back up in no time. He just wishes there were no other lives at stake.

*“Mydei,”* Phainon’s voice calls, suddenly emerging from his side and parring the blade aimed once more at Mydei’s neck just in time. “You can rest now, yeah?”

If Phainon is here, it means everything is going according to the plan. It means it doesn’t matter if they are overrun by the enemies anymore as there won’t be any other casualties. It’s two of them against everything else now, as soon as Mydei recovers.

Mydei allows himself to drop both of his hands. His body lurches forward and he coughs, finally letting the liquid out. There is so much ichor that it looks like he vomited it onto the ground. He raises his head just a little bit, right in time to catch one last worried glance from Phainon sent in his direction before the man throws himself fully into the battle. He dances around the yet again growing number of enemies, a sword through one, a slash through their artificial limbs, a cut to his own thigh.

He should be there to cover him and protect the blind spots, not dying. What if Phainon——

Mydei holds his hand steady, the other raised just slightly in case the girl trips to catch her before she can hit the ground. She keeps her arm up, fingers grasping onto his clumsily as she spins around without a care. It's hard to keep his mouth set in a thin line when her cheerful laughter rings loud in the air.

Mydei doesn’t startle when another hand settles onto his own before slipping down and extracting the child’s hand to twirl her around himself a few times. The man then crouches next to her, waiting patiently until her overexcited giggling subsides.

“I think your mom is waiting for you, Miss.” Phainon points over Mydei’s shoulder with a warm grin.

The girl jolts, standing on her tiptoes to catch a sight of her mother and then she’s off, breaking into a small jog. Mydei trails after her with his gaze, watching as she barrels into her mother who stands near the stairs, clearly having been waiting for some minutes now if the bags by her feet are anything to go by.

Phainon drops onto the bench Mydei is sitting on, his leg bumping against Mydei. Mydei presses back, watching the woman lean down and say something to the girl. Her daughter whirls around on her heel to face them again and cups her hands around her mouth eagerly, presumably so that her voice can carry better.

“Thank you, Lord Mydei!” She yells for all to hear, a giant grin spread across her face. The woman smiles softly and picks her up, going up the stairs as the girl continues waving at him until they reach the top and disappear from sight.

“Got yourself a new fan?” Phainon asks with clear amusement. His lips are pressed tightly, likely to avoid a smirk that would serve for nothing but getting on Mydei’s nerves.

“Hardly,” Mydei replies dryly and places his hand on the stone surface of the bench to the side, resting his weight on it. “I noticed the kids didn’t want to play with her. Thought I would ease her boredom until her parents come back.”

“Such a noble heart,” Phainon teases, shifting forward into Mydei’s space. That annoying smirk slips through, so much for the effort he put into concealing it at first.

Mydei places his hand right on top of Phainon’s curved mouth and pushes him back roughly with an eye roll. “Like you never entertained a gaggle of brats. They swarm you at a moment’s notice if you stay idle anywhere for a second too long.”

“It’s just hero worship. I’m not as good with them as you are.” Phainon shrugs and points over his shoulder with his thumb to where the girl disappeared. “It goes beyond that with you; they always end up *adoring* you. They talk about you on the streets with respect but familiarity, they come back to you with the silliest of requests, knowing you won’t refuse.” He says as if he doesn’t embarrass himself in whatever plays the kids drag him into almost on a daily basis.

“Sounds like someone else I know,” Mydei hums, tapping the stone as he stares at Phainon. “Do you relate to those kids, Deliverer? I should have figured that you come to bother me at any waking moment because you never grew up.”

He ignores the fact the comparison implies that Mydei always gives in to Phainon’s requests. Because, whether he likes it or not, he does. Be it an offer to stroll through the market with no store in mind, a spar, a competition, a simple conversation, *anything* Phainon asks for after grumbling about it and letting loose some scathing comments.

“Here I try to compliment you, and this is what I get?” Phainon sighs dramatically, feigning heartbreak at Mydei’s words. “Gotta admit, it is tempting to be spun around on your shoulders. Would you let me make you a flower crown? Or do you want to play *house* with me like you did with those three siblings last week?”

*Embarrassing.*

Feeling heat rise to his cheeks, Mydei tears his eyes away from the man and clicks his tongue in annoyance.

“Words come out of your mouth, and yet it’s like your pea-sized brain——"

Mydei’s eyes snap open, the awareness of his surroundings coming back to him within seconds. He pushes himself up to kneel and scans the battleground, noting several new dead bodies littered around him. Phainon is still fighting a few steps to the side, one against four.

Three, when he spins around and uses the momentum to sever one of the heads.

He is doing well for himself, nothing he would need assistance with. Mydei is about to slowly pick himself up and make his way over. Without a hurry, wanting to observe Phainon in his element. Phainon may not truly love the battle, but he is still a sight to behold all the while. Sword through the chest then drags up through the torso to ensure the damage is lasting, and it’s another one down, two left.

A blur of movement in the corner of his eye catches his attention, and his body moves before his brain can properly catch up. Mydei scrambles to his feet, still unsteady in the wake of blood loss, and nearly trips in his haste to close the distance and get himself in the path between the object and Phainon.

He stretches his arm out as far as he can, and watches in relief as the arrow embeds itself in his palm. The sharp tip points straight at Phainon’s spine, mere centimeters away from it.

Phainon turns his head, just briefly to check on Mydei, eyes widening momentarily when he notices what he’s been saved from, seconds away from the tragedy. Mydei will taunt him about covering all of his spots for the next few days, but that’s not for now.

Deeming Mydei safe enough, he returns to the fight and disposes of the last two combatants without much of a hassle, two minutes at most as Mydei’s gaze stays locked on the distance in search of any other stray arrows.

“Might want to move for the cover if you’re done,” Mydei says as another body drops with a thud.

“Could be a good idea, yeah,” Phainon replies, a little short of breath.

It’s a brief distance to find a collapsed pillar they can sit behind without the worry of any archers catching them off guard while being able to keep watch on what’s ahead.

Phainon rests with his back to the stone, not quite panting but breathing accelerated enough to show that exhaustion is catching up with him. Did he have trouble with his section? Mydei made sure the area *he* was sent to was the most difficult one, swarming with enemies at every step so it shouldn’t be that. Or was it rushing over to Mydei’s side right after the demanding fight of his own that has worn him out? He doesn’t have the luxury of temporary death granting quicker regeneration, after all.

“See,” Mydei begins, catching his attention. He shakes his hand in the air, gold streaming down his forearm sluggishly. “*I* can catch them.”

Phainon’s eyes jump from the arrow to Mydei’s face and then back. For a moment, his expression appears as if he wants to throttle Mydei, but then it clears as a huff escapes from between his lips before it evolves into a chuckle.

“I fear we have varying definitions of ‘catch,’” he tells him and takes hold of Mydei’s wrist.

Gently, he guides it closer to himself. Then, he grabs the arrow’s shaft firmly in one hand to avoid it jostling Mydei’s wound and deftly snaps it in half with his fingers. He pulls it out of Mydei’s palm and discards the broken arrow somewhere on the ground. Phainon sighs and gives one last once-over to the injury before releasing it as well.

It will heal quickly enough, nothing major. Mydei can already feel his skin attempting to stitch itself back together.

“Perhaps the word means something else in Kremnoan,” Mydei muses idly. He wonders how many times he can use the excuse before Phainon realizes it makes no sense. Could take weeks, knowing the man. He changes the subject before Phainon can properly register the comment for future reference. “We ought to dispose of that archer before the next wave hits.”

Phainon groans petulantly at the reminder. “It’s *far.* I don’t want to double back for just one Titankin being a mild annoyance to us.”

Like a child being told to clean their room, or whatever chores the kids are reluctant to perform nowadays.

“There is a discarded lance right there that I can throw at it.” Mydei points with his chin at one of the corpses. “Or I can run back to the other archer I killed before you got to me for its bow. It’s close enough.”

A thoughtful look crosses Phainon’s features and Mydei already regrets giving him a choice in the first place. He should have just gotten up and done it instead.

“Let me try with the lance?” Phainon says like he is asking for permission.

Mydei rubs the bridge of his nose. It may be posed as a question, but Phainon won’t take no for an answer in this scenario. There is no danger to their lives right now to claim the need to make fast and accurate decisions.

“You will fail miserably,” Mydei points out, knowing it’s a lost cause. “Must I remind you that you are not trained in *throwing* it?”

Phainon makes a dismissive sound, smiling like he’s never been more confident about something in his life. “It can’t be too hard.”

Predictably, Mydei ends up having to search for that damn bow.

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Phainon lets out a short hiss, nose wrinkling in annoyance at the pain when Mydei slaps his hand away from fiddling with the bandage covering his calf. The cut on it was so deep it required stitches, made worse when Phainon refused to slow down after gaining the injury. Mydei cursed him out for his carelessness all the way to the healers. He doesn’t have the

healing factor as strong as Mydei's. If he lost the damn leg, it would have been gone forever.

"What's that for?" Phainon pouts, cradling his hand in the other one performatively.

"For being an utter moron," Mydei retaliates. He won't be fixing the damn bandage again if Phainon manages to accidentally loosen it up. *Again.*

"But it itches," Phainon explains, leg bouncing up and down restlessly when the option to scratch it is taken away from him.

"That means it's healing." Mydei places his palm on Phainon's knee and puts the slightest pressure on it to still the movement. "Stop being a brat about it."

Phainon, true to his nature, sticks his tongue out at Mydei. He has half a mind to reach out and yank him by it to show what exactly he thinks of that gesture. With the patience of a saint, he reigns the impulse in and only sends him a withering glare.

"Speaking of," Phainon hums, back to semi-seriousness within a second, "*You* have been doing much better lately."

"I did not notice I wasn't doing well in the first place," Mydei replies. He doesn't know what Phainon is talking about. The mission was as mundane as they come, with barely any scratch on his body to speak of.

"You didn't die today but, generally, you come back to us much faster than you used to," Phainon explains, voice light as if he is talking about the weather. If it ever even changed, in Okhema. He is not fooling Mydei, though, not with the way his gaze is ever-so-slightly sharper than usual, boring into Mydei with certainty. "Once upon a time, it got to the point where you were out for four days without a sign of returning. Now, unless the death is particularly violent, you tend to be up and running within fifteen minutes at most. Usually less."

Phainon is more observant than people give him credit for.

This process of regaining his ability to resurrect in a timely manner was a painfully slow and gradual thing. Mydei remembers waking up entirely disoriented after those four days, uncertain whether that's what he had been longing for, before. Reliving four days of his past, four days of nothing but peace and carefree companionship with no pain to cloud it or hang above his head, was pleasant. Coming back to worried glances and hushed whispers, having Phainon so concerned that he refused to leave his side for a week with the dark shadows beneath his eyes and his energetic sunlight-like personality dimmed into something muted, was *not*.

That was the most extreme case out of all his resurrections. The average, back then, was a few hours.

It took more than a year since those four days of toeing the line separating life and death without a single thought spared for the consequences. A year of his body steadily decreasing the time needed to get back, alternating between shorter and longer time frames.

If someone were to think on it for a minute, it's easy to realize he got better. But after so long, he doesn't think it occurred to anyone else just yet. They could be keeping quiet about it, sure, not willing to tempt fate. Anaxa knows, he knew well before it shortened to a brief few minutes.

But he has a suspicion that Phainon has been paying careful attention to it for a long, long time.

"I wasn't aware you were keeping track," Mydei says very carefully, aiming for sarcasm. He might have succeeded in sounding casual, he thinks.

"Of course, I am," Phainon scoffs in indignation. The sharpness gives way to fond amusements, like Mydei is being an idiot. "It's obvious to everyone and their mother, Mydei."

And maybe he is right. Perhaps it is obvious.

Phainon is *always* there when Mydei wakes up. If not, he somehow always seems to find out one way or the other and checks on him, as if Mydei didn't regain his full health each and every time. He *would* know the

process of Mydei's recovery better than Mydei himself. He stayed by his cold corpse for hours before, watching as it put itself back together and blood slowly resumed circulation.

"Then there was also that, uh, day." Phainon continues with a touch of uncertainty. He looks unsure whether he wants to bring it up but decides to push through regardless. "A while ago. Where you disappeared without anyone knowing where to, and you came back with. You know." He gestures to his own neck, making a line with his fingers on it awkwardly. "I got worried."

Mydei's mind comes to a screeching halt at that.

He forgot about that day. With everything happening, with that many deaths in his tally, with so many of them at his own hand, it's not something that would stick to his memory much. He remembers it now, though. The hope for Phainon to not realize anything is wrong, then the relief when the man never brought it up in the coming days.

His eyes lower on their own accord as he removes his hand from Phainon's knee, feeling as if the touch is beginning to burn him alive. Phainon catches it mid-air before he can move it away too far, taking a firm hold on it. Like he is afraid that letting Mydei retract would lead to him withdrawing entirely.

It's a valid concern.

What is Mydei even supposed to say to that?

Phainon would see through his lies, there is no doubt. Mydei doesn't feel inclined to voice the truth out loud either.

"We don't have to talk about it. I won't bring it up again. Ever, if you don't want to," Phainon rushes to reassure him. He pulls on Mydei's hand with insistence, waiting until he reluctantly looks at him again. A small and pleased smile greets him. "I simply wished to tell you that I am incredibly relieved to see things got better for you. That whatever used to haunt you so deeply removed its claws from your soul."

Phainon's happiness over the matter is evident even without the explanation.

His expression is so earnestly, *painfully* elated for something so insignificant. So many years and Mydei still doesn't entirely comprehend what the issue is. Why does it matter whether he recovers quickly if the end result is always the same? He won't die permanently; it's not in the cards for him.

He can see the advantage of being able to pick himself back up rather quickly during the battle, back to fighting within minutes of his death.

But that's not what Phainon was worrying about, clearly.

"Your absurd sentimentality is noted," Mydei eventually manages to put some words together. He mentally praises himself for sounding only mildly strained.

Phainon doesn't take the poorly executed provocation to get him bickering, and instead chuckles as if he expected the answer to be just that.

"May I ask what changed?" Phainon asks instead, and runs his thumb in slow circles against Mydei's palm, waiting patiently to see if Mydei judges the question as too much vulnerability for one day.

*What changed?*

The focus of his memories in the event of death. His past is now mostly painted in muted memories rather than shown to him in graphic details. His present, delivered right back to him with a bright exclamation 'Here is where your happiness lies'. The realization he doesn't have to chase the ghosts of his past to feel like his life is worth all the misery.

Not waking up alone and being left to get stuck in the memories of the past anymore. Someone who notices the small details, who sees and understands him. Bugs him to no end but backs off without a question when Mydei needs his own space.

The feeling of loving and being loved, wanting to be better again for it.

What *hasn't* changed?

But Mydei won't ever be able to say any of that. One day, maybe, after it's all over. When he no longer has to die every other day for the greater good, cracked to pieces by the prophecy and his past and the Titans. He will sit Phainon down and tell him in great detail what his experience with Thanatos' domain is.

He will push through the humiliation of it, and he will admit to the way Phainon forced himself into this excruciating process. The Boy Savior, as always hard at his work without even knowing what he is doing.

"I suppose I can say I started feeling more tethered to the reality," Mydei eventually sums it up without giving much away. Phainon nods eagerly, beaming at him so brightly that more words spill out without a conscious decision. "Found something that reminds me of why I should come back."

Oh, for—

Phainon's eyes almost *sparkle* at hearing that.

"Did you, now?" It's said teasingly, but there is newfound determination in there too. His leg starts bouncing again as well, except it doesn't appear to be stress-induced anymore. His thumb presses into Mydei's skin momentarily before easing the pressure.

This is a more familiar territory, revolving around the effortless push-and-pull, frustrating one another and toeing the line of flirtation neither of them will ever act on. "Why, do you think you can determine what exactly it might be?"

"You are easy to read," Phainon responds with a shrug. Mydei cannot think of a single person that would agree with that statement. The smile sharpens into an awfully self-confident smirk within a moment. "How about a bet? Give me two clues and I will make one guess."

Now *that* is beyond familiar.

And dangerous, considering the context. Unfortunately, Mydei has never outright refused a bet or competition from Phainon. Sometimes he distracts him or changes the direction of it. It wouldn't be possible this time.

While he thinks, Phainon brings his injured leg up onto the railing to make himself more comfortable, putting his chin on the knee. The bandage finally slips loose at the movement, riding down his calf a little until the edge of the stitches comes into view.

"What of the reward?" Mydei asks as he extracts his hand from the hold and fixes the dressing. It's quick work, tying it off securely and tucking the long end back into the folds. It doesn't seem to be bleeding anymore either.

"Whatever the winner chooses," Phainon responds immediately, not wasting a single second to think about it.

"That confident, huh?" Mydei asks, getting a shameless grin for the trouble. Of course he is overconfident about this. Mydei will ensure he never lives it down if his guess is too far off the mark. "You could regret that shortly."

"I'm not particularly worried." That unfaltering certainty would be concerning if Phainon wasn't known for acting before thinking things through properly once an idea strikes him. "Well? Or are you scared I will make you do something embarrassing?"

"Maybe in your dreams," Mydei rolls his eyes, barely catching the way Phainon's face contorts as if he is holding in a snort. Two clues, was it? He ought to make it as vague as possible. "First: It's something I never imagined I would have come to appreciate much, in the beginning. Second: It's something that has become a part of me."

It should be fine, he thinks. Could be a trait of his own he has learned to accept, could be a newfound passion that proved to be difficult at first. There are many things to drag up to those two descriptions.

“You are insufferable,” Phainon groans after a moment of stunned silence, running his hand down his own face before lifting it up to flick at Mydei’s forehead without much strength put into it. “How am I supposed to say it after this?”

“Just say you don’t know,” Mydei says with a half-hearted glare. “I won’t hold it against you.”

“It’s me,” Phainon ignores the provocation. His brows furrow, only a touch of hesitation coloring his voice. “*I* am the answer.”

Mydei’s brain freezes for a beat.

Then, it restarts and decides that moving on and pretending it’s not as big of a revelation as it is might be the best direction to take. Don’t put importance on it, and Phainon might drop it.

Wishful thinking, but he can always try.

“That’s correct, congratulations,” Mydei says, fighting to keep his jaw unclenched and voice carefully neutral. He feels his ears burning, but he hopes his hair blocks them from sight. “What do you want?”

“Huh? Really? Are you sure?” Phainon’s eyes widen comically as if he didn’t actually expect to guess correctly. So much for his bravado. “I mean, I was *hoping* I would be right, but— Are you really not pulling my leg? You could be trying to cover up something more embarrassing.”

Phainon isn’t one to usually question the circumstances of his victory, as he often resorts to cheap and dirty tricks to win against Mydei. He will claim his win and run with it, refusing to hear another word.

Why is he questioning it now, of all things?

It’s a strange day. Mydei foresees a migraine in the not-so-distant future from all the back and forth they keep going through right now.

“What, for Titans’ sake,” Mydei says tiredly, “Could ever be more embarrassing than admitting to *this*, Deliverer?”

“You— You might be right.” He clears his throat, eyes snapping off to the side as light pink rises on his cheeks before he focuses on Mydei again. “For the record, I can echo those sentiments right back at you. You’ve also become something I’m not sure I could ever part with.”

Something loosens in Mydei’s chest, warmth blooming and spreading through his veins. “You would be fine without me.”

“Agree to disagree,” Phainon laughs, tilting his head as he regards Mydei happily. “So, make sure to come back each time, yeah? I’m not sure about you but, personally, I can’t stand the thought of living without a part of myself.”

Alright, this might be getting a bit too sappy and sentimental for Mydei to handle without consequences.

“Name your price, Deliverer,” he decides to get them back on track. “It’s getting late.”

“Mn,” Phainon hums, tapping his chin as he considers his options. Or pretends to. The way he exaggerates a thoughtful frown tells Mydei he already knows what he wants. “Can I kiss you, then?”

What.

“What?” He manages to get out a strangled question, almost choking on his spit. *“Phainon.”*

“What, we agreed on anything,” Phainon reminds in a rush, the pink on his cheeks turning bright red. “Just a small peck, nothing more. It can be platonic if you want? I just. I have to do it at least once if I have an opportunity to. Please.”

Mydei closes his eyes and rubs the inner corners in an effort to keep himself grounded.

Titans, they are both such a mess.

But hasn’t he decided a while ago that if Phainon chooses to apply his recklessness to the ambiguous state of their relationship and wrestle it into something more definitive, Mydei will follow his lead?

This might be the end of them. This relationship with Phainon might be the most valuable thing Mydei has ever achieved. There is a high probability it will break Mydei or Phainon, one day. He would do a lot for his people and his friends, things many people disagree with. He is already one of the most powerful Chrysos Heirs.

How much stronger will he be upon ascending to godhood, as he is destined to do? Who will be able to stop him from bringing destruction upon this world if he finally glimpses the divine bliss that love brings just to have it ripped from him?

It's a tragedy in the making.

“Alright, then.” And yet, he will follow Phainon into it without a single regret.

Phainon’s eyes widen in both surprise and delight for a fraction of a second before he surges forward, hands lifting to cup Mydei’s jaw and bring him closer. Their mouths clash together painfully, making Mydei chuckle at the eagerness. He closes his eyes and shuffles in Phainon’s direction, blindly snaking his arm around Phainon’s middle to pull him the rest of the way.

They fit together so well that Mydei feels he could lose his mind about it.

As promised, Phainon pulls back just slightly without deepening the kiss. He doesn’t go very far, palms still soft against Mydei’s skin and warm breath mere centimeters away from his face.

“I will be a little selfish for one more moment, sorry,” Phainon says quietly.

Phainon, selfish? A laughable notion.

He drops his hands and wraps one of them around Mydei’s waist as his head moves lower until his chin rests on his shoulder. Hugging. Mydei

flexes his fingers, resisting the urge to get Phainon even *closer,* pulling their bodies flush together.

“I love you, you know,” Phainon confesses right next to Mydei’s ear, sending a shiver down his spine. He has wanted to hear these words for so many years, never daring to hope he would get a chance to. “And I think you love me, too.”

“You *think?”* Mydei repeats, his voice strained. Mydei no longer remembers what it felt like to *not* love Phainon. “For some incomprehensible to me reason, yes, I do.”

“Already breaking my heart?” Phainon giggles despite the words, the sound overflowing with barely restrained happiness. “Shame on you, Mydei.”

“Continue on with your blabbering and that love will be reduced to reluctant like,” Mydei says flatly.

Phainon pulls away with a grin, unconcerned with the empty warning. Mydei is quite certain Phainon could turn on them all and he would still love the fool. Carefully, Phainon brings his injured leg over the railing to straddle it.

“We should have taken this step years ago,” Phainon muses, and his smile dims a little, regretful of the wasted time.

That won’t do.

Mydei leans forward again to knock their foreheads together, huffing when he sees Phainon’s eyes cross. “What does it matter when we shared this feeling all along, regardless? Don’t yearn for the missed moments when we were happy with what we had.”

He straightens up, enjoying the way Phainon tries to follow back into Mydei’s personal space. Mydei takes his hand and brings it up to his own nape. Phainon’s fingers tangle in the hair resting against it without a further prompt.

“Besides, even if our current lives are doomed to be cut short before we can make the most of it, know for certain we will find each other again in every other life,” Mydei vows with everything he has. He is sure there is no life of his where Phainon doesn’t end up taking up the space in his heart, sooner or later.

*“Yeah,”* Phainon breathes out, but it comes out a little heartbroken. “Yeah, we will.”

Before Mydei can try and say more to erase any traces of sadness, Phainon moves back into Mydei’s space and presses their lips together again, this time slower and gentler.

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Ridiculous.

Mydei only feels the sharp annoyance as he hurriedly attempts to guide some of his insides back through the wound on his stomach. He doesn’t have much time left. Having all his organs on the inside should speed it up a little bit, there is a chance he will wake up before Phainon finds out about this.

He will question the blood staining him so thoroughly, but Mydei can distract him enough that he drops the subject without having solid proof of how horribly wrong the fight went. Well. Not that wrong by Mydei’s standards. What’s one measly wound when he defeated the beast terrorizing the locals and slaughtering anyone who steps into its vicinity?

He sits down and leans against a wall, moments away from losing consciousness. He wonders whether it would have been faster overall if he just plunged his gauntlet into his heart instead immediately after gaining a victory. Quicker death *could* lead to quicker recovery. But if his guts were

spilled onto the floor, it would have taken longer for his body to recreate them from scratch.

So, he took a risk of wasting a precious minute of the unnerving sensation of stretching his own skin wide open to slip the soft tissue back where it belongs, to be healed and reattached.

He has exactly three seconds to feel the regret of it when he hears footsteps rapidly nearing his location, a low curse slipping out when Phainon rounds the corner and his eyes immediately fall on Mydei's prone body, expression twisting in——

His teleslate pings.

Mydei pays it no mind, continuing the conversation without a pause.

It pings again. And again. Three times within a minute.

He assumes it's an update from one of his lieutenants that he has been waiting for, cut into three messages for better pacing or whatever other reason.

Mydei manages to put together four more sentences to convey his point across before the teleslate starts pinging again. Now more insisted, making a sound every five seconds or so.

At the seventh one, Mydei feels a vein in his forehead twitch. After the twelfth, Aglaea's brows rise ever so slightly.

"Maybe you should check that," she says mildly. Another ping. "Could be an emergency."

If it truly was an emergency, someone would have run in and got him already. If it was an emergency, there wouldn't be any time to blow up his teleslate in such a foolish manner.

"There will be an emergency once I get my hands on him," he mutters under his breath, digging the small device out of his pocket. He is about to unlock it when the implication of the sentence hits him. He looks up to find

Aglaea carefully covering her mouth with her hand. “…I didn’t mean it like that.”

“No, no.” Aglaea waves him off, sounding a little choked from keeping in what must be a chuckle. “Of course not.”

Titans. Mydei really detests how quick he is to blush.

He banishes the thoughts of what that implication could have potentially entailed was it something *more* than just that and instead focuses on the spike of annoyance at the source of it.

Exhaling, he unlocks the teleslate.

What greets him is nothing but a spam of that one red chimera sticker, looking all miserable. Mydei feels his eyelid twitch. He scrolls up through what can only be described as an army of chimeras to find a singular text message at the very top.

*‘Are you done yet?’* It reads.

All that ruckus—and accidental humiliation—for Phainon just being a brat?

“We should reschedule,” Aglaea speaks up, already shuffling the papers together while Mydei tries to keep the grip on the teleslate slack enough not to crack it. “Tell Phainon Tribbie wasn’t satisfied with his recent test results.”

Ah, so she also wasn’t happy with the interruption. If she mentions this, it means she might talk Tribbie into a punishment of sorts to *motivate* Phainon.

Mydei nods at her and turns on his heel without a word, already parsing through the locations and which one of them Phainon is most likely to be at. He will——

The world is tilted at an angle, Mydei’s head propped up on a shoulder, rising gently with every breath taken. It takes a brief moment for him to

properly recall what the situation is, wincing as he remembers that Phainon will not be happy with him in the slightest.

And yet, he took care to make him comfortable for the brief few minutes he was out. Sits with him so closely they're touching in a straight line from their feet to their heads. Mydei's hand is loosely held in Phainon's, both covered in gold. Always so caring even in his anger.

Mydei intertwines their fingers, flipping their hands over so that his is on top.

"You just had to run off ahead of everyone else," Phainon says quietly. There is no annoyance to be heard, just simple sadness. That's somehow worse. "What happened to watching each other's backs?"

And just like that, guilt stabs through Mydei.

He didn't think much, honestly. He caught a fresh trail and made a split-second decision to follow, trusting that Phainon would defend the rest of the group if something were to happen. There was a chance that the teenagers last seen entering the caves could still be alive, and so he didn't want to waste any time.

Instead, he found their dead bodies, body parts scattered in a trail further in.

It seemed like an obvious choice to take care of the beast as soon as possible. He has defeated much more powerful foes before on his own, after all.

Phainon is capable. Always right there, always keeping up without breaking a sweat. It's easy to forget sometimes some communication in these situations would be appreciated.

"I apologize," Mydei says, as sincerely as he can. He lifts their joined hands to his lips and presses them against Phainon's knuckles.

"It's fine," Phainon breathes out, resting his head against Mydei's. Always so quick to forgive.

“Phainon,” he calls because this is important. He doesn’t want Phainon anywhere out of his sight without his knowledge in moments like these either, so he *gets it.* If he expects Phainon to let him know he is going off to throw himself into his foolish heroics, he should return the favor. “I won’t do it again.”

“I know you won’t,” Phainon tells him, not a shred of doubt in his voice.

Mydei gives them five more minutes of peace before he nudges Phainon, signaling it’s time to get going.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

They’ve been walking around for hours now without a clear goal in mind. Mydei is enduring this only because there isn’t any pressing matter for him to attend to at this moment. And because Phainon seems to be working himself up for something. Mydei can be patient if he wants to, even when it comes to Phainon who is known to grind Mydei’s self-restraint into dust.

He is quieter than usual, frowning with a conflicted expression every few minutes, hands kept in his pockets as if he doesn’t usually hang all over Mydei at any given opportunity. Even the civilians would be able to see something is up.

Mydei trails after Phainon up the stairs and gives Tavananna a short nod as they walk around the Holy Candle. He initially assumes Phainon is taking them to the Garden of Life, but he unexpectedly takes a turn left, leading to the small gazebo. Mydei corrects his course to follow, and the old lady waves back at him from her usual spot. She quickly looks Phainon up and down as they walk past and then faces Mydei to smile at him knowingly.

Well. Okay.

Whatever assumptions she might be making, at least he knows she won't be eavesdropping or spreading rumors about this. Mydei should make time to talk to her soon as well, he knows she only wishes for some company to pass the time with.

Making the mental note, he turns his attention back to Phainon, watching as he trails his fingertips along the golden edge of the Altar of Fortune. He comes to a stop in front of the railing, waiting until Mydei joins at his side.

"Well, uh. I would like to give you something," he says awkwardly, apparently done wasting time, one hand still in the pocket as he scratches the back of his head with the other.

That's it? Not that Mydei isn't appreciative of anything Phainon may give him, but that's what all this build-up was for? He half thought Phainon was searching for a way to break some bad news to him.

"Is that why you've been so high-strung all day long?" He asks with an amused smirk, unable to reign in the desire to needle him a little for it. "Because you wished to give me something?"

"Don't make fun of me," Phainon grumbles with a glare. He bites his lip with uncertainty, eyes shifting away and up to the figure of Kephale looming over them.

"I am simply relieved I'm not about to hear you are deflecting from the Chrysos Heirs or some other dramatic endeavor I anticipated to hear about when faced with your peculiar behavior," Mydei backtracks, suddenly feeling guilty. He is just glad no one else is there to witness how quickly he gives in. "It was taking you so long, I started thinking you would chicken out of whatever you needed so much mental preparation for."

"I thought there wasn't a term such as 'chicken out' in the Kremnoan language," Phainon retorts, directing his narrowed eyes back at Mydei.

Mydei lets out a noncommittal hum to that. "Well? What is it that has you in such a state, Deliverer? Don't keep me in suspense," he changes the subject.

Phainon mutters something under his breath, too quiet to pick up the words. He takes Mydei's forearm and forces his palm to face up. The grip is a little too tight, betraying his nerves. He finally takes the other hand out of his pocket and carefully holds it up above Mydei's. There are two seconds where he seems to be reconsidering his actions before he clicks his tongue and drops something small unceremoniously.

Just as quickly, he lets go of Mydei and takes a step back. What is he so skittish about?

Mydei forces himself to tear his eyes away from Phainon's conflicted expression to look down at the small gift, and feels his breath stutter in his chest.

"I caught the gem during one of my antic appraisals. It reminded me of the ones adorning your necklace and armband, so I took it without thinking, really. It's only when discussing it with Theodoros that I found out it's a legitimate crystal of Kremnoan origin, the exact same as yours. So, I, uh—" he cuts his rambling off abruptly and clears his throat. "I thought it would suit you? I commissioned a craftsman to make an earring with it for you, and I just made some suggestions… And, ah, here it is."

Mydei swallows roughly, the blue and gold glinting up at him.

It's... A lot.

The jewelry was originally gifted to him by Hephaestion.

Ironically, the occurrence was a quite similar affair as this one. Hephaestion hesitated just as much, awkwardly changing the subject every few minutes until Mydei pressed and got a clear answer for the reason for their meeting. He liked it immediately. Worn both the necklace and armband at every opportunity since then as a sign of his appreciation and devotion to his… dear friend. It's the piece of his homeland that he cherishes the most, unburdened by the expectations that come with the rest of his heritage.

With Castrum Kremnos in ruin, he never expected he would see more of these gems.

And now, Phainon did what he thought impossible and found more, without any knowledge of their importance.

“Ah, is it not to your liking?” Phainon asks with clear anxiety, mistaking his silence for discontent. “It’s okay. I can take it back and extract the gem out of it so you can do whatever you want with it. There is one more of them that I kept in its original form just in case. Or maybe you don’t want it at all, that’s also fine, I’m sure it’s not that im—”

Phainon reaches forward to take it back. Mydei closes his hand around the earring protectively, careful not to damage it. He looks up at him with a glare, only for it to soften when he notices the pink dusting Phainon’s cheeks and tension coiling in his shoulders.

“It means a lot,” he clarifies quickly. It’s perfect. “Thank you, Phainon.”

He carries a reminder of one of his most cherished friends on his person at all times. It didn’t escape his attention that, coincidentally, the color scheme matches perfectly another important individual in his life. He would like to think that Hephaestion would enjoy the knowledge that Mydei found another new meaning to associate with the jewelry he wears. Will wear.

Relief visibly washes over Phainon’s features as he exhales. “I’m glad.”

He grins at Mydei, but the flush stays on his face. This time due to happiness rather than embarrassment, Mydei hopes.

Mydei unclips the current earring in one swift move and keeps his hair away from his ear with one hand while dangling the new accessory in the air with the other. Phainon tilts his head in confusion adorably, blinking at it.

“Won’t you put it on me?” Mydei asks with amusement.

Phainon’s lips part just slightly, and Mydei thinks the blush deepens a little, but it might be his eyes playing tricks on him. He nods enthusiastically and hurries closer, taking the earring back.

Mydei bites his lip to suppress the shiver trying to travel down his spine when Phainon decides to brush his thumb around the earlobe. A completely unnecessary movement that he should snap at Phainon for. Before he can find his voice to do just that, Phainon presses the earring against th——

Mydei comes to sluggishly.

The room is dark, and his mind feels dizzy, confused about his whereabouts. Wasn't he just hanging out with Phainon? Didn't they…

Ah.

There is weight wrapped around his chest, and another thrown over his legs. A familiar weight.

Mydei turns his head to see Phainon plastered to his side, drooling onto the pillow with a frown etched between his brows. Without thinking, Mydei lifts his hand and tries to smooth it out, fingers trembling. Odd. He has never had any issues with keeping his hands steady.

Another hand snakes up to cover Mydei's, bringing it down to rest against Phainon's mouth. Worried eyes blink open, scanning Mydei's face. "Poison wore off?" He asks, voice rough.

That would explain it. "Seems so," Mydei replies. He doesn't feel any active agent in his body, only the leftover side effects. The memory of what happened hasn't quite returned just yet, but he doesn't say it to spare Phainon from unnecessary nerves.

Letting out a sigh, Phainon wraps himself around Mydei more securely, burrowing his head against Mydei's neck. "Been a while since the last time you were gone for hours."

Oh. And that explains the clinginess. Not that Mydei is complaining, he quite enjoys physical contact of any kind. "Sorry," he says into Phainon's hair.

“Not your fault,” Phainon replies immediately, voice muffled. “Get some more rest, we should be just past the Parting Hour.”

Mydei hums in agreement, turning onto his side so they can sleep face-to-face. Chest-to-chest. Phainon’s leg slips between Mydei’s thighs naturally, arm pulling him flush against his body within a second. Not a centimeter of space left.

Whenever Phainon is run ragged with concern, he likes to sleep while holding Mydei and being held by him at the same time. An arrangement that produces stiff limbs and one that they fall out of in the middle of the night each time, but who is Mydei to refuse it when it helps Phainon?

Mydei cannot say he doesn’t find it calming as well, to fall asleep while entangled in one another so thoroughly.

The last thing he sees before exhaustion takes him under is the glinting blue of his jewelry resting on the bedside table, taken off his body by Phainon to make him more comfortable in bed.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Fighting in ruins is tricky. It’s fine on the ground floor, the first one isn’t too bad either. Anything higher than that, and one wrong step can result in the floor caving in beneath you and lead to fatal injuries.

Mydei would know.

And so when he sees Phainon backing off from the Titankin to catch his breath, stepping on the spiderweb-like fractures staining the ground, he thinks it might be one of these. There is a creaking sound and the floor caves in under Phainon’s foot just a little, making him stumble. One more step and he’s heading down.

Mydei's body moves on its own accord as soon as he notices, digging his heel into the stone right at Phainon's side and *feeling* the ground shake. He grabs Phainon's coat roughly and shoves him forward with as much force as he can.

He only briefly catches the sight of Phainon scrambling on his feet, reaching out to grab Mydei despite not being anywhere close enough. And then, the ground disappears from underneath him.

Mydei doesn't fall for long, notices just a flash of white hair over the edge high above as he plummets through the air. Of all places it had to be some tower-like construction they found the hostiles at. He braces himself for impact, assuming it's his spine that's going to suffer the damage once he hits the bottom. Except he is shocked out of it by hitting something else, what he cannot begin to guess as a cracking sound ringing so loudly in his ears that he briefly thinks he might go deaf from it overtakes every other sense. Only then, he registers that he must have hit——

A loud whining sound emerges from behind him. When he looks over, Phainon's hand flaps around in the air, vaguely gesturing for something.

In one sharp move, Mydei moves the curtains to the side and unleashes the unforgivable fury of eternal sunlight right onto the bed.

"Ruthless," Phainon mumbles with another discontent noise. He promptly slides the large pillow out from beneath his hand and shoves it right over his face.

So excessively dramatic.

With an amused sigh, Mydei walks back to bed and sits on the edge, leaning over Phainon to wrestle the pillow down just a little. Phainon makes a valiant effort to keep it smashed into his own face, but his sleepiness leads to his grip eventually slipping and Mydei succeeds in his task. Phainon's eyes are still stubbornly squeezed shut, so Mydei cards white hair back and presses a chaste kiss against the forehead.

Unexpectedly, one strong arm snakes around his neck while the other wraps around his waist and he is manhandled back onto the bed with a very clingy partner on top of him.

“I win,” Phainon grins cheekily, pecking him on the forehead in mimicry of his previous action.

Mydei doesn’t mind losing if it’s like that. “Win what?” He still asks, putting on the slightest bit of irritation to keep up the appearance.

Something in Phainon’s eyes tells him he doesn’t buy it. “Another few minutes of sleep,” he replies and flops down right on top of Mydei. It’s a lot of weight of pure muscle descending on his poor ribs.

“Are you sure you wouldn’t rather be doing something else?” He asks casually, waiting until Phainon shakes his head against him to wrap his legs around Phainon’s hips and turn them around. Phainon’s hands lift up to support him by reflex as Mydei straddles him, looking down with a smirk. *“Really?”*

Mydei moves a little lower, settling himself right on Phainon’s crotch, and feels his cock twitch in interest beneath him. He sees the last traces of sleep vanish from Phainon as his eyes darken, fingers squeezing Mydei’s flesh just——

“I think you spilt your head open,” is the sentence that greets him back into the living world.

A very stark contrast to what he was just experiencing. He breathes deeply in and out, trying to get himself back into the right gear. He is just happy that resurrection makes it literally impossible to get even remotely hard.

“Did I?” That’s what the loud crack must have been. His skull fractured. Has this happened before? He doesn’t remember.

He pushes himself up into a seating position, wincing as a wave of nausea hits him.

“Your hair is drenched in gold,” Phainon says drily. He lifts his hand up and moves his fingers around right beneath the crown of Mydei’s head, searching. “There was an uneven spot right here when I got to you and checked you over, but it was already healed over. I don’t fancy looking for the brain tissue to be sure that’s what happened, though.”

“No, you are right,” Mydei confirms, his own hand joining Phainon’s to try and find the spot. He feels the barest of indentation. His gray matter is probably sprayed on some stone one or two floors above, presumably having hit his head on some ornament that was sticking out of the wall.

“Sorry for being careless,” Phainon apologizes, with a thin smile that Mydei knows speaks of the particular brand of self-deprecation that makes Phainon feel incompetent.

“It’s fine, that’s what I’m here for—I won’t ever let you fall,” Mydei reassures. They aren’t perfect, but they cover each other’s weaknesses. Making mistakes is only natural. “Just look out for things like these when I’m not there with you.”

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Mydei laughs.

It’s an ugly, deranged sound.

He feels like he is finally truly in his element, free to throw himself at the enemy with all he’s got. Over and over and over again. Without concerned eyes welcoming him back, chastising him for the disregard he has for himself.

He loves Phainon, more than life itself. But this is what Mydei has been made for, destined since birth to face the Titan and die by their hand. To

slay them, after the glorious battle. Phainon’s worry doesn’t have a place in this fated encounter, as proven by his reluctance to leave Mydei’s side.

Besides, even if he forced the man to leave with the outworlder and search for the solution, his presence hasn't vanished. It’s there in every death he experiences, a short respite lasting seconds or minutes to see his beloved before returning to the bloodshed with renewed vigor.

A wrath of a man against his God.

He fights for vengeance, for his dead mother, and for his people forced to leave behind their livelihoods. For Okhema’s protection, and for Amphoreus’ future. For Phainon. To last against the Titan long enough and allow Phainon to gain that forsaken Coreflame. If anyone can resist its corruption, it would be Phainon, should he prove himself in the trial.

He has long since realized he and Phainon might be a little unhealthy, by normal and mortal standards. The list of how concerningly and deeply gone they are for one another is too long to even begin describing all the items figuring in it. The least concerning of it all is the amount of time they spend together.

It seems innocent to think about it. Where Mydei is, Phainon should be not too far away. Where Phainon goes, Mydei will shortly follow.

Until Mydei dies a hundred deaths in a row, each time being shown a unique piece of time selected from their daily lives. He would have thought there would not be enough of them, that the cycle would reset, and his old memories might come back to him. He knows better, though. The moments he has shared with Phainon over the years are nowhere near the risk of running out.

And it’s just as well because he doesn’t necessarily want to part with them.

It could be because of how little time he needs to recover, nowadays. Not enough to burn through the memories as quickly. Not that long ago, he had wished to remain in that space between death and life for as long as feasibly possible.

Now, Mydei grins as wide as his lips can stretch as he tears through the Titan’s body. He keeps grinning when his body is skewered with multiple swords. He breaks the blades easily with his gauntlet, slipping off them with four holes in his stomach and gold leaving a trail in his wake.

Everything goes black before he can form another thought, and Phainon’s delighted laughter greets him into thirty seconds of warmth and affection, and reassurance, before he resurfaces and resumes their glorious fight, filled with a fresh wave of determination.

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"Found you," Mydei breathes out with a smile and puts his hands on top of Phainon's when the sword skewers deeper into his stomach. He pushes himself further onto it to get just a little closer.

All is silent and entirely still, Caelus' warning dying on his lips as even the enemies freeze around them. For another moment, Phainon's eyes show no recognition as he stares at Mydei with the self-satisfaction of having defeated a foe so easily, as he is sure that's what the Strife has portrayed him as to his beloved.

He sees the exact second the illusion breaks and confusion takes hold, quickly fading into realization, cracks filled with devastation at the reality of what he has done.

"Mydei," Phainon calls, hands twitching underneath Mydei's. "I didn't—what, I—"

Mydei musters the last of his strength and lifts his hand to Phainon's cheek, smearing ichor that dripped onto his palm across it.

"Can't wait to find out what memory of you I will see this time," Mydei says as his knees buckle. Phainon follows him to the ground, hands slipping

away from the weapon and to Mydei's face with desperation.

"Oh," he hears Caelus breathe out somewhere behind him at the display but they both pay him no mind.

"I'm *sorry."* Phainon makes a distressed sound, somewhere between choking and heaving, eyes jumping between Mydei's face, and the blade struck through his chest.

Mydei huffs and tips himself forward to press their lips together and he tastes sa——

A shadow blocks the warmth of sunrays Mydei was basking in. It's been a tiring day spent on pointless attempts to convince Krateros he knows what he is doing.

Maybe Krateros can see through the false confidence he is portraying. Mydei suspects it's more about the values that differ from his Master's as more time passes.

Already irritated, he blinks his eyes open just to see the insufferable grin of the most annoying man to ever walk the Amphoreus. Figures he won't even let him rest in peace.

"I wouldn't have guessed that His Highness is slacking away in the middle of the day," Phainon's voice grates in his ears, the title mocking.

"Have you got nothing of importance in your life?" Mydei asks, closing his eyes again lest the sight of his insufferable face causes him to lash out.

"Could ask you the same," Phainon replies, kicking lightly at Mydei's unclothed side, right between the ribs.

Mydei lets out a controlled breath, calming the anger that spikes through him. It would be unbecoming to retaliate for such childish antics.

"So, you saw me resting and decided to specifically come to bother me," he sums up, getting another kick for his trouble with slightly more strength.

"Are you so hopeless that you cannot entertain yourself for one damn minute?"

Phainon gives no indication that he heard him. Words flying through one ear and exiting through the next. "We should spar." Another kick. "Unless that's above your station*, Your Highness.”* The title is almost a sneer in his mouth.

The tip of Phainon's boot digs into the delicate skin covering Mydei's ribs. It doesn't hurt as much as it would have hurt a regular man, but the small burst of pain crosses the threshold of annoyance Mydei is willing to put up with.

His hand shoots forward and wraps around the man's ankle, pulling towards himself roughly. It’s laughingly easy to catch Phainon off guard and disturb his balance.

*"Fuck,"* Phainon yelps as he goes down, crashing onto the ground pathetically. He glares through the wince at the pain, probably having hit his tailbone. Would serve him right. Mydei hopes it’s fractured. “What crawled up your ass and died?” Phainon hisses at him with a vicious glare.

He looks about as fierce as a disgruntled chimera, letting out a high-pitched *awoo* to let others know it’s very bad and dangerous and should be feared. Which is to say not at all.

“A certain nuisance that first roped me into a battle lasting ten days just to call a draw and then refused to leave me fucking be ever since,” Mydei says in a disinterested tone.

“No wonder you’ve got no friends to speak of,” Phainon says scathingly and yet doesn’t make any move to get up and go away. Mydei ought to speak with Tribbie about not enough time spent in the books or something.

“And *you* have any?” He snorts at him derisively.

He doesn’t know Phainon, nor does he wish to. It doesn’t change the fact that like recognizes like. They are both broken in a similar way, with the

world's worth of expectations resting on their shoulders as they put on different facades for the same reasons and keep a safe distance from everyone. Outlanders, both forced out of their homelands and into this grand prophecy of ushering in the Era Nova.

Phainon’s expression freezes at the words for a long moment, before he puts on a forced grin. Mydei almost smirks at the twitch in his clenched jaw.

“So, what I’m hearing is you are too scared to fight me again?” Phainon reverts back to his original point, like a broken record. Mydei has had to deal with all kinds of people throughout leading the Kremnos Detachment across Amphoreus, and he still thinks he’s never had the displeasure of meeting anyone as infuriating. “I get it. It would ruin your reputation if you openly lost, oh Prince of Strife.”

Mydei slaps his hand over his forehead. He regrets ever looking in Phainon’s direction, not to mention giving in to the request of a fight. A lapse in judgment that just might cost him whatever is left of his sanity. “You are the bane of my existence, Deliverer.”

He moves to get up, pretending not to see Phainon’s victorious smirk. It’s only because——

For once, it truly feels like waking up from a dream.

Mydei sits up as soon as he opens his eyes, no pain to be felt. He figures it’s the side-effect of dying in the trial, dampening the consequences of death for someone who wasn’t its prime target.

Unlike Phainon, who failed it.

His eyes immediately lock onto the body lying on the bed next over. Phainon doesn’t look any worse for wear either, save for droplets of sweat covering his forehead and the pinched expression. Like he is having a nightmare. Not as if he’s been pulled out of a failed trial and barely escaped with his soul intact.

Belatedly, he realizes a person stands by Phainon's bed, staring at Mydei with *pity.*

He swallows his pride and clears his throat. "Will he be alright?"

"Physically, he is perfectly healthy," the healer explains gently. Mydei has heard this tone of voice before, always used on the family members when talking about their loved one's dire condition in an attempt to keep them from panicking. "It's up to him whether he wakes up. But Lord Phainon is strong, so I would be optimistic."

Mydei nods in gratitude and gets up from the bed. No dizziness, no bone-deep ache in his muscles, no nerves firing wrong signals to his brain as they recover. As if he never died. He walks the short distance to the other bed and climbs into it, pulling Phainon's head onto his lap. He doesn't care for the healer's presence, nor the rumors that might resurface from this. His hair is damp against Mydei's fingers as he brushes the strands out of his eyes.

He barely hears when the healer makes an excuse, seeing Mydei doesn't require anything, and exits the room. He has no doubt others are waiting just outside, about to get an update on their conditions. They can wait.

The healer's words run on a loop in Mydei's brain. What an ironic twist of fate. He doesn't know how many times Phainon must have heard the exact same sentence while waiting at Mydei's beside.

And, is *this* the consequence of Mydei's inaction?

He knows the demigods spun the threads to orchestrate the trial just so, aware Phainon wouldn't be able to pass it. He doesn't fault them for it, even if he himself had hoped Phainon would succeed. Mydei knows that forcing Phainon into the equation was the only way to make him realize no one can step up to walk the path prepared for him alone.

It's something he has dreaded since the moment he first learned of it. Phainon must have noticed, doubling down on his insistence to bear the

Coreflame of Strife not long after they started growing closer. Always the Boy Savior.

It might be time to step up and be someone Phainon can also depend on. To buy everyone enough time for Phainon to shine as his destiny dictates, and bring the beginning of the new world.

Mydei stays for a bit longer, carding his fingers through the white hair and wiping sweat off with his own sleeve, silently mapping out the course of action he should be taking from now on.

What could be hours later, he finally emerges from the room when Phainon shows no signs of waking. He only hopes Phainon will be back on his feet before it's time for Mydei to leave Okhema.

"...I did my best," he says to the peanut gallery that greets him outside the door, expressions dispirited.

☼ ♆ ☼ ♆ ☼

Mydei loathes it. Of course he does.

If he and Phainon weren't two parts of a whole, complementing one another in every possible way, he would have taken him with him. He is sure Phainon is one wrong word away from throwing all expectations of him into the wind and following Mydei to Castrum Kremnos himself. But as it is, they are both the strongest of the Chrysos Heirs. Someone has to stay and protect Okhema while Mydei performs his duty.

He knows Phainon would do the same in his shoes.

And so, Mydei is about to walk away from him for the last time, but a hand wraps around his forearm and pulls. Here he thought they would have been able to go their separate ways without a thousand 'Wait a second's. That

said, Mydei still lets himself be easily spun around and feels Phainon push against him, pressing their lips together.

It’s a chaste kiss, nothing like the ones they share behind closed doors. A mirror to their very first kiss, something gentle filled with words unsaid. It’s a short, sweet thing that lasts until Phainon shows how much his self-restraint has improved over the years and moves back just slightly, keeping their foreheads together.

“We will find each other again,” Phainon says, determination ringing clear through it.

Mydei leans back in, stealing one last peck before he pulls away entirely. “In this life, and the next one.”

All in all, Mydei doesn’t mind bidding farewell to his lover.

He might be much stronger as a demigod, but he will see Phainon soon enough in the brief periods of respite the death will allow him for. After all, he won’t perish from anything less than a strike to his tenth thoracic vertebrae, and he is determined for Phainon’s hand to be the one to deliver it.

Chapter End Notes

> i don't know what happened, this was supposed to be 14k words in total. i guess you can treat a doubled word count as an apology for taking this long?
> also this isn't 100% edited because it's late and i don't know what i'm reading anymore
>
> small explanation because i think it's obvious but i'm also tweaking thinking it might not be: mydei's regen went down after he got to okhema and allowed himself to sort through what he went through,

trauma response, depression, etc. then it gradually goes back to its original state as he heals, whether he realizes or not, by having steady support in phainon, experiencing so much love directed at him, and having someone he cares about so deeply as well. so, by the time we hit canon it's back to it's perfect state
that's not to say his mental health is squeaky lol. he and phainon are lowkey codependent, their lives revolving around one another. also look at the last few sentences — mydei has learned nothing, he still reverts to "if things are bad, i can always fall back on the memories", he simply changed his anchor (so he is more stable, yes)

i also hope that the transition between a memory and life isn't too confusing. i wanted it to be a very quick transition, something disorienting which mydei loses himself in, because it *feels* like he is experiencing it all over again and he himself isn't aware he is dead during it. in the end, i went back and added an additional "—" to every transition cuz i overuse that shit outside of it too

you can tell when i started to think "damn. i should learn to pace better and write longer scenes" lmfao. that being said, it's actually a goal of mine. *if* i manage to get out another work for phaidei, it's going to be much longer. more thorough characterization, hopefully more world-building, phainon pov instead of mydei for once, more npcs, and most of all better pacing and longer scenes, like i said. i'm not making any promises, my track record is horrendous. i would love nothing more than to write it, truly. but it's not exactly up to me seeing as my interest in ships fades *fast*. i'm not over phaidei just yet, but this was difficult to finish. since i'm done, i have to take care of two pretty time consuming tasks i was prioritizing writing over. i'm not sure i will have motivation to write afterwards lmao. that being said, i could very well come back in three months with some 80k word giant, you never know with me (hell, i never thought i would write four whole works for any ship)

!!!!!!! THERE IS NOW A FANART!!! a thousand thanks to the artist once again because holy shit?? you can find it on tumblr or on bsky!

just click on those words and it'll take you there :D. go give love to the person who drew it or i'll eat you omg

THERE IS NOW A SECOND FANART?!!?!! another thousand thanks to another artist for choosing my work for the fanart, i'm not feeling fragile about this wdym. you can find it also on tumblr or on bsky. for anyone still reading this work, go and appreciate it, i'm begging you. it's so pretty and soft aaaa

i sincerely hope you enjoyed as i'm pretty proud of this work hahah
@kj_crwn on twt
here is the phaidei spotify playlist i listen to when writing if you're into that. it's also the most sure-fire way to check whether i'm writing — if i'm adding songs, it means that i most certainly am

Works inspired by this one

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